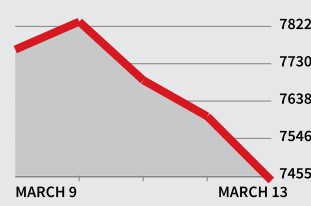


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 74563.92 (-1470.50)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23151.10	-488.05
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.47	-0.40
US Dollar (in ₹)	92.45	+0.26
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	157765.00	-1897
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	260488.00	-7813

‘STRAIT’ TALK.

PM Narendra Modi calls Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, flags Hormuz blockade risks to LPG supplies **p2**



AUTO FOCUS.

The VinFast VF6 brings big numbers to a hot segment of EVs. Has it done enough, though? **p4**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

QUICKLY.

TOP LEVEL CHANGE

Adobe CEO Narayan to step down after 18 years



Bengaluru: Shantanu Narayan will step down as Chief Executive of Adobe after nearly two decades in the role, the company said on Tuesday, adding that he will remain chair of the board once a successor is appointed. Shantanu joined Adobe in 1998 as a Vice-President and General Manager of its engineering technology group. He was appointed President and Chief Operating Officer in 2005 and became the CEO in 2007. During his tenure as CEO, the company recorded its highest levels of revenue. **p10**

HIGHER SUPPLIES

Sugar industry urges govt to raise ethanol blending

New Delhi: Encouraged by a higher share of ethanol supplied against commitments compared with grain-based distilleries, the sugar industry has urged Food Minister Pralhad Joshi to consider raising ethanol blending beyond the current 20 per cent. **p8**

Key indices lose 5.5% in worst week in 15 months as oil surges

FUELLING CRISIS. FIIs sell relentlessly; ₹20 lakh crore wiped out in m-cap; volatility rises

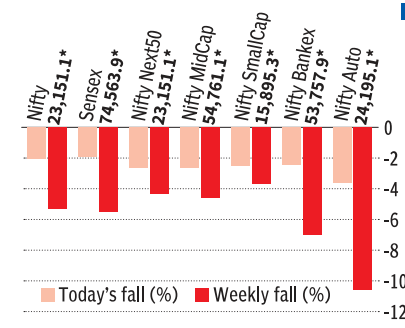
Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Markets capped their worst week in over 15 months on Friday, with investors losing about ₹20 lakh crore in market capitalisation over five sessions as the US/Israel-Iran conflict drove crude oil past \$100 per barrel and pushed the rupee to an all-time low.

The BSE SENSEX plunged 1,470.50 points, or 1.93 per cent, on Friday to close at 74,563.92, while the Nifty 50 fell 488.05 points, or 2.06 per cent, to settle at 23,151.10 — a fresh 10-month low. The BSE market-cap dropped to ₹430.02 lakh crore on Friday alone, a single session wipe-out of ₹9.7 lakh crore. For the week, the SENSEX shed 7,375 points, or 5.5 per cent, and the Nifty lost 1,300 points, or 5.3 per cent — marking Nifty’s worst weekly fall since the Covid pandemic crash of March 2020.

ALL SECTORS IN RED Sectoral damage was sweeping. Nifty Bank fell 7 per cent; Nifty Auto plunged over 10.5 per cent, its worst weekly performance since

Bear grip



close **LTP (₹)

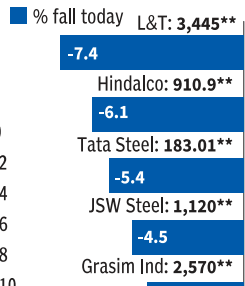
March 2020; Nifty Midcap shed 4.6 per cent; and Nifty SmallCap fell 3.65 per cent. On the BSE, 3,439 stocks declined against 858 advances; 563 stocks hit 52-week lows.

Three developments shook the markets. One, the closing of Strait of Hormuz that sent Brent crude surging, a critical blow for India, which imports nearly 88 per cent of its oil.

RUPEE AT NEW LOW

Two, the rupee hitting an all-time low of 92.45 per dollar amid relentless FII outflows even as the RBI intervened by selling dollars. According to provisional data, FIIs off-loaded shares worth ₹10,716.64 crore.

Friday fury



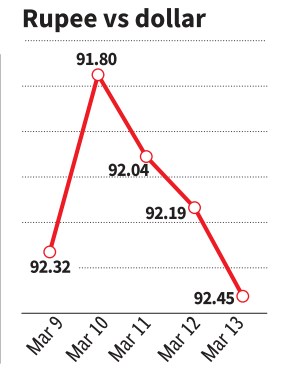
Three, the Trump administration’s trade investigation into India adding another layer of uncertainty.

The India VIX climbed above 22, up over 13 per cent for the week.

GOLD, SILVER DOWN

Gold prices fell by ₹1,904 on Friday to ₹1,58,399 per 10 g against ₹1,60,303 logged on Thursday due to a weak trend in the global markets. Similarly, silver was down at ₹2,60,488 per kg against ₹2,68,301, according to the Indian Bullion and Jewellers Association of India.

Vikram Kasat, Head Advisory at PL Capital, said the sell-off appeared more sentiment-driven than funda-



mental. “The correction appears more sentiment-driven rather than a reflection of weakening domestic fundamentals. Any meaningful correction should be seen as an opportunity for long-term investors to gradually accumulate quality large-caps and sector leaders with strong earnings visibility.”

Dilip Parmar, Senior Research Analyst at HDFC Securities, pointed out that the pressure on the rupee will not go away soon. “Surging global crude oil prices and sustained foreign fund outflows, amid heightened risk aversion, have kept the rupee under significant pressure,” he said.

More reports **p2, p3**



CONNECTED BY EMPATHY. DRIVEN BY PURPOSE.

Proud and honoured to be Great Place to Work® Certified

Kauvery Group of Hospitals operate 12 units across Tamil Nadu and Karnataka, delivering tertiary and quaternary care with compassion and competence. Our team gives us strength, versatility and diversity. Women are at the core of our passionate team and nearly 58% of them are first-time professionals. Our people first culture inspires confidence, commitment and a shared conviction to deliver high-quality care at an affordable cost. This Great Place to Work® recognition reflects the values and culture we practise every day.



US opens forced-labour trade probe against India, 59 other countries under Section 301

ANOTHER SETBACK. US Ambassador Sergio Gor says he expects countries, including India, to honour trade deals

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

The US has initiated a fresh Section 301 trade investigation against India and 59 other economies to determine whether they have failed to effectively prohibit the import of goods produced with forced labour, thereby burdening American commerce.

The probe, launched on Thursday by the Office of the US Trade Representative (USTR), covers economies that include China, the EU, Japan, Canada, Bangladesh, Vietnam, New Zealand, Pakistan, South Africa, and Australia, among others.

The move comes just a day after the USTR initiated a separate Section 301 invest-

igation against India and fifteen other economies over alleged “structural excess capacity” in manufacturing that Washington says threatens American industries.

“If any determination is affirmative, the trade representative must determine whether action is appropriate, and if so, what action to take,” said the USTR in its notification.

New Delhi is examining the implications of the investigations and their potential impact on India’s exports as well as the ongoing bilateral trade agreement (BTA) negotiations with the US, sources tracking the matter told *businessline*.

‘WIN-WIN DEAL’
US Ambassador to India Ser-



HOPE REMAINS. Both sides continue to engage in discussions aimed at concluding a mutually beneficial trade deal

gio Gor said on Friday that Washington expects countries that have entered into trade deals with the US, including India, to honour them.

“I think India would do so also because it is a win-win deal,” he said at a media event in Delhi.

Commenting on the US Supreme Court ruling invalidating the Trump administration’s reciprocal tariffs

imposed on trading partners, Gor said the judgment applies only to a specific part of US trade law, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act.

“The Supreme Court has not adjudicated dozens of other tools that are at the President’s disposal. There are multiple other sections, including Section 301 that just got invoked yesterday. So, we fully expect nations

that have made those deals with the US to honour them,” he said.

India has been recalibrating its approach to trade negotiations with the US to assess the implications of the court ruling that struck down the reciprocal tariffs, a source tracking the matter said.

“If India is penalised under the Section 301 investigations, it may have a negative fallout on the talks,” the source said.

TALKS CONTINUE
Government officials, however, added that both sides continue to engage in discussions aimed at concluding a mutually beneficial trade agreement.

Indian exporters, who currently face a temporary 10

per cent global tariff imposed by the US, instead of the high tariffs of 50 per cent imposed last August, are worried.

“The Section 301 investigation adds further uncertainty to the textiles and apparel sector, which is already under significant stress due to developments in West Asia,” the Confederation of Indian Textile Industry said.

Announcing the probe, US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer said that despite global consensus against forced labour, governments have failed to adequately enforce bans on goods produced under such conditions.

The USTR has invited public comments and requests to appear at hearings by April 15.

Oil spike may hurt India less this time: DBS Bank

Our Bureau
Mumbai



India may be better placed to absorb a surge in global crude oil prices than in previous cycles, thanks to stronger macroeconomic buffers and more diversified crude sourcing, according to DBS Bank.

In its latest investment outlook for 2026, the Singapore-based lender said that while higher oil prices remain a key risk for India’s macroeconomic stability, the country’s ability to manage such shocks has improved compared with earlier commodity cycles.

India imports more than 85 per cent of its crude oil requirements, making the economy currently sensitive to global energy price swings. Historically, sharp increases in oil prices have widened the country’s current account deficit, pushed up inflation and strained government finances.

However, the impact of the current oil cycle may be less severe, said DBS.

“India imports most of its oil, so higher crude prices will affect the economy, including the fiscal deficit and the external balance,” said Joanne Goh, Senior Investment Strategist at DBS Bank.

At the same time, she said that the economy is better positioned to handle such pressures. “India has gone through oil price spikes in many cycles before, but this time the macro impact may not be as severe as earlier,” said Goh.

RUSSIA-UKRAINE WAR
One factor helping cushion the impact is India’s diversification of crude imports in recent years. Since the Russia-Ukraine conflict, India has significantly increased purchase of discounted Russian crude, which has helped moderate the country’s im-

port bill even when global prices remain elevated.

STILL ATTRACTIVE
Despite near-term macro risks linked to oil prices, DBS said India continues to stand out as a long-term investment destination within Asia.

Global companies looking to diversify supply chains beyond China, along with rising investment in infrastructure and manufacturing, are expected to support India’s growth prospects over the medium term, she said. However, the bank cautioned that equity markets could still face cyclical pressures if crude prices remain elevated. “For equities as a whole, there are some cyclical risks right now mainly coming from the oil price,” said Goh.

DBS also said alternative assets will help investors navigate volatile global markets.

According to Hou Wey Fook, Chief Investment Officer at DBS Bank, private markets such as private credit and private equity remain attractive long-term allocations despite periodic concerns about liquidity.

“Despite all the noise that’s happening today... investors who hold these strategies for the longer term should see this largely as short-term volatility,” said Hou. “Entry points look more attractive as valuations sit at a decade-low compared to public markets, with small- to mid-market deals offering the clearest balance of value and execution.”

Agencies raise inflation forecast for FY27 as oil spikes, ₹ depreciates

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

With uncertainty looming due to the war and the resultant rise in crude prices and depreciation of the rupee, global and domestic agencies have raised their inflation forecast for FY27.

Retail inflation based on Consumer Price Index (CPI) rose to 11-month high of 3.21 per cent in February, mainly on account of higher prices of food and precious metals. Now, experts expect crude price to rise, with its cascading effects having an impact on the headline number.

Nomura said the inflation reading reaffirms the broader trend of disinflation



UNCERTAINTY LOOMS. Nomura has revised inflation forecast to 4.5 per cent from 3.8 per cent

until February, but the energy price shock triggered by the West Asian tensions has disrupted this calm.

“We have revised our oil price assumption to \$86/bbl for 2026, and our FY27 (April 2026 to March 2027) inflation forecast to 4.5 per cent

from 3.8 per cent previously, as food-related base effects will combine with the energy price shock to lift headline inflation rate,” it said.

A note by HDFC Bank said that in its baseline scenario, the CPI inflation is expected to average at 4.2 per cent in

FY27 versus 2.1 per cent in FY26.

However, “if the upward pressure on crude and petroleum products sustains in the coming months, we see an upside risk to our forecast,” it said.

TWO FACTORS
In its research report, QnataEco listed two factors — longevity of the crisis and severity of disruption to global energy supplies — to analyse the impact of the energy-led price shock on CPI inflation.

It said if the war continues over the next 1-2 months, its fallout while being severe in the very near term, could possibly be managed via internal buffers and policy decisions (excise duty cuts).

+ ‘30% hotels closed as hospitality industry faces LPG shortages’

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi



With the LPG supply crunch disrupting hospitality operations across key cities, industry players said allocation of around 20 per cent of the average monthly commercial LPG requirement announced by the government should be implemented swiftly so that it translates into distribution and availability on the ground. Industry bodies said several restaurant outlets and hotels across key cities have begun suspending operations temporarily due to the paucity of LPG.

Pradeep Shetty, V-P, Federation of Hotel & Restaurant Associations of India, said: “Based on feedback from our members, we estimate that nearly 30 per cent of hotels and restaurants are shut due to the ongoing shortage.”

GLIMMER OF HOPE
He added that the government’s announcement regarding allocation of around 20 per cent of the average monthly commercial LPG requirement to help address the shortage offers a glimmer of hope.

“The key concern remains how quickly this allocation translates into distribution and availability at the ground level. Moreover, the allocation may still be insufficient to sustain operational costs and meet the hospitality sector’s demand, particularly for establishments handling large-scale catering and high-volume food preparation,” he added.

Shetty cautioned that “establishments that have continued operations have largely done so under curtailed conditions, with reduced operating hours, limited menus and restricted kitchen activity, in order to conserve available gas stocks. If fresh supplies do not reach the market soon,

more establishments may be forced to temporarily shut operations in the coming days, particularly small and medium-sized eateries that operate with limited reserves”.

A senior executive with another industry body noted that closure of restaurant outlets has been reported from several key cities, including Chennai, Bengaluru, Pune, and Mumbai, among others. “Despite the government’s announcement on Thursday, the availability of commercial LPG supplies for restaurants has not improved on the ground. We are hopeful of an improvement in the situation by the weekend,” he added.

ADVISORIES ISSUED
Meanwhile, the FHRAI and NRAI issued advisories to members to conserve available fuel, temporarily rationalise menus to reduce high gas consumption items, integrate electric appliances such as induction cooktops and convection ovens where feasible, and adjust operating hours to focus on peak service periods.
KB Kachru, President, Hotel Association of India (HAI), and Chairman, South Asia, Radisson Hotel Group, said the industry body is hopeful that recent steps announced by the government will lead to the hospitality sector getting uninterrupted supply of LPG. He added that this will provide the much-needed relief amid ongoing supply challenges.

Trump: Iran’s new supreme leader is alive but ‘damaged’

Reuters
Washington

President Donald Trump said he thinks the new Iranian Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei, whose father, the former supreme leader, was killed on the first day of the US and Israel’s war on Iran, is alive but damaged.

Khamenei has not been seen by Iranians since his selection on Sunday by a clerical assembly, and his first comments were read out by a television presenter on Thursday.

An Iranian official told *Reuters* on Wednesday that the newly appointed supreme leader was lightly injured but was continuing to operate, after state television described him as war-wounded.

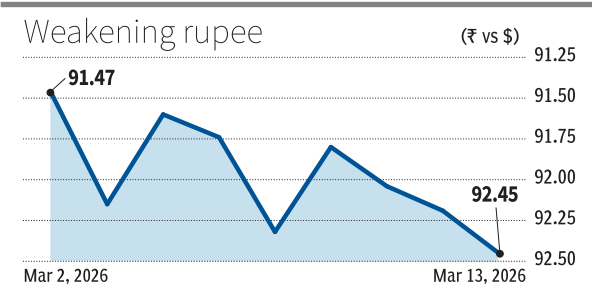
Rupee at all-time low of 92.45/dollar

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The rupee closed at an all-time low of 92.4550 per US dollar in the week ended March 13, with factors such as the intensifying West Asia war, hardening crude oil prices and FPI-related outflows from the continuously falling domestic equity markets weakening the currency.

The rupee closed the week ended March 13 (Friday) at a record closing low, down 72 paise when compared with the previous Friday’s close of 91.74. In the preceding week, the rupee had closed 77 paise weaker.

RBI INTERVENTION
Since the Israel-US alliance war with Iran started two weeks ago, the rupee has weakened about 150 paise.



The central bank has been intervening in the forex market, defending the currency at various levels to reduce its volatility against the dollar.

OIL SHOCK
The rupee opened about 16 paise weaker at 92.3450 per dollar on Friday, and hit a high/low of 92.3050/92.4850. Amit Pabari, MD, CR Forex Advisors, said that a

stronger dollar, coupled with rising oil prices, will exert pressure on the rupee.

“Since the conflict began, currencies of major energy-importing countries have weakened against the dollar, reflecting the higher cost of energy imports and the increased demand for dollars to pay for them,” Pabari added.
Dilip Parmar, Senior Re-

search Analyst, HDFC Securities, observed that the rupee weakened for the second consecutive week, settling at a fresh record low as geopolitical worries weighed on the currency.

BULLISH BIAS
“Surging global crude oil prices, driven by escalating tensions in West Asia and sustained foreign fund outflows amid heightened risk aversion, have kept the rupee under significant pressure. Further, aggressive dollar demand from importers and traders intensified as the currency breached the record high,” he said.

Parmar noted that spot dollar/rupee maintains a bullish bias, with immediate resistance anticipated between 92.50-92.70 and support at 92.05.

Two Indians killed, 10 injured after attack in Muscat

Asian News International
New Delhi

Aseem Mahajan, Additional Secretary (Gulf), on Friday shared updates about the two Indians who died in Muscat. He also provided an update on *Safesha Vishnu*, which came under attack, noting that efforts are underway to repatriate the 15 Indian nationals.

He made the remarks during the Inter-Ministerial briefing on recent developments in West Asia.

Mahajan said of the 10 injured, five had been discharged while others were receiving treatment with none having serious injuries. He underlined that the mission remains in close touch and continues to provide all assistance.

“There was an attack and in this incident two Indian nationals have died. We express our deepest condolences to their families. Of the 11 injured, 10 are Indians. Our mission is in close touch with the concerned company and local authorities and is rendering all assistance,” said Mahajan.

Two expatriate workers were killed after debris from a downed drone fell in an industrial area in the Sohar province of Oman, *Al Jazeera* reported, citing the state news agency.

Citing a security source, *Al Jazeera* reported that the drone crashed in the Al-Awahi industrial area, resulting in the death of two foreign workers and injuries to several others. Another drone was shot down in the Sohar province during the same incident.

On the update regarding *Safesha Vishnu*, which was attacked on March 9 near Basra in Iraq, Mahajan said that the 15 crew members were currently lodged in a hotel in Basra.

Efforts are also underway to transport the mortal remains of the deceased Indian national and for safe repatriation of the rescued 15.

Putin’s ‘hidden hand’ guides Iran’s strikes

Bloomberg

Russian intelligence support for Iran’s deadly retaliation against the US, Israel and Gulf allies, as well as concerns China may also be helping Tehran, demonstrates deepening ties among US adversaries as the war with Iran continues to widen.

Moscow is currently providing Iran with various forms of intelligence, including satellite imagery and drone targeting tactics, in an effort to help Iran hit back at US forces in the region, according to people familiar with US and Western intelligence.

It’s uncertain to what degree the intelligence given to Iran is effective and timely, and how regularly Russia is providing actionable information, according to a source, who spoke on condition of anonymity. But it reflects a crucial relationship highlighted by Russia’s reliance on deadly Iranian Shahed at-

tack drones in its ongoing invasion of Ukraine.

“No one will be surprised to believe that Putin’s hidden hand is behind some of the Iranian tactics and potentially some of their capabilities as well,” said UK Defence Secretary John Healey at a military briefing in London on Thursday.

“Patterns of Iranian attack have the hallmarks of the way Russia is attacking Ukraine,” he said, adding that was to be expected “knowing how closely that alliance of aggression has been growing over the last few years”.

Russia and Iran have deepened military cooperation in recent years after Moscow turned to other US geopolitical foes, including Tehran and North Korea, for support after its global isolation following the 2022 invasion of its neighbour. Now there are concerns that China could also be providing Iran with some form of support.

QUICKLY.

Ultraviolette announces BaaS scheme



In a bid to reduce the initial purchase cost, Bengaluru-based Ultraviolette Automotive has partnered with Ecofy, a non-banking financial company, to offer battery financing. Under the programme, called Battery Flex, buyers can pay a monthly subscription of ₹2,499 per month over the course of five years. On the completion of the term, the battery ownership will be transferred to the customer without any extra charges. This option has reduced the upfront cost of UV models by up to ₹1.5 lakh.

Renault Bridger compact SUV concept unveiled



The French company's upcoming SUV is slated to debut in India by the end of 2027 and could be positioned between the Kiger and the Duster. Its overall boxy shape, complemented by square-ish wheel arches and cladding adds to its rugged visual appeal. Further, the 18-inch wheels, 200-mm ground clearance and the tailgate-mounted spare wheel hint at its off-road capability. The Bridger will be built on the R-GMP platform and will be available in petrol, hybrid and EV powertrains, making it one of the most versatile SUVs in the segment.

QJMotor rolls out SRK 421 RR supersport



The Chinese brand's ever-growing line-up has a new entrant in the form of a 421cc inline-four-powered supersport that belts out close to 77 bhp at 14,000 rpm and 3.87 kg-m at 13,000 rpm. Brembo brakes and fully-adjustable suspension from Marzocchi add to the list of impressive hardware. Further, there's multi-level traction control and different riding modes. All of that wrapped in an aggressive, futuristic design tips the scales to 191 kg. Is it coming to India, though? Unlikely. But if it does, it could give the Kawasaki Ninja ZX-4R a run for its money.

@The MotorGram

On a Charge

CURRENT AFFAIRS. The VinFast VF6 brings big numbers to a hot segment of EVs. Has it done enough, though?

YASH GAWDE

Ruman Devmane

Until a few years ago, picking a side between car manufacturers was easy. The upstarts were going up against the incumbents, the age-old rivals were too busy scrambling for the last step of the podium and the rest you simply didn't make eye contact with. EVs are great levellers, however. For one, legacy counts for precious little. And since largely everyone is new to making them, it's all a mostly level-playing field. How you categorise VinFast is, therefore, entirely up to you. In its brief but seriously ambitious history, it has made BMW-based cars and rebadged GMs; today, it produces a range of electric scooters, cars and buses. Its parent company, Vingroup, may have started out in the early 1990s as a producer of instant noodles, but it can now sell you anything from homes to cyber security, AI technology and even healthcare. In other words, VinFast may be new to your automotive vocabulary, but that doesn't warrant it to be taken lightly.

IT'S A 6 The VF6 is the brand's entry point in India and while its makers classify it as an SUV, its 190 mm of ground clearance aside, it isn't strictly one. Regardless, it certainly isn't unattractive. With its clean European lines and large dimensions, it isn't something that will go unnoticed either. The car pictured here is the top-spec VF6 (Wind Infinity; the lower variant is Earth) which features a 59.6-kWh battery pack, common to both variants. Power output is higher, at 201 bhp as compared to the Earth's 174 bhp. VinFast claims a range of 463-468 km between the two variants as per MIDC parameters and states it can be fast-charged from 0 to 70 per cent in 25 minutes. Those are heavyweight numbers in a segment populated by cars such as the Tata Curvv.ev, Hyundai Creta Electric, Maruti Suzuki e Vitara,



A TOUCH TOO MUCH. Most controls are routed largely through the touchscreen, which takes time getting used to. Overall cabin quality is quite impressive. Boot space isn't adequate, though

Toyota Urban Cruiser Ebella and a few others. On a specification sheet alone, then, the VF6 has quite the edge in most areas. Impressive brochure, sure, but how does it fare in real world?

CABIN CLASS Let's get inside. The cabin is rather well-finished, exuding a sense of premiumness even if it takes its minimalism a bit too seriously. You see, there's no instrument cluster behind the small and really nice thick-rimmed steering wheel, and pretty much every control is routed through the driver-oriented touchscreen — yes, from the Level 2 ADAS features to air-con settings and even the rear-view mirrors! Essential information is relayed through a head-up display and thankfully, you can select gear using high-quality toggle-style physical switches. There's a 360-degree camera, too, and a pretty impressive infotainment system with good sound output. Before I forget, there's no

'start' button. You simply long-press the brake pedal to 'wake' it up. I began my drive with the car charged to 96 per cent at which point it displayed an expected range of 437.5 km. Staying in Eco mode with regenerative braking set to the highest step effectively translated to an intuitive single-pedal drive mode, with the experience heightened by the neatly controlled cabin noise insulation levels. The ride quality, too, seemed quite well-balanced over the city's uneven road surfaces and it did feel decidedly upmarket. There's a likeable heft to the steering and the soft-touch materials used liberally across the cabin made it a nice place to spend the day in, despite the antics the city overwhelms with at times. **FAST FORWARD** Progressing to Normal mode from Eco, you will notice more eager acceleration although Sport mode, in all truthfulness, is a bit excessive. Under hard acceleration, the VF6

produces a tremendous amount of torque steer which its 225/55 R18 Goodyear tyres simply can't keep up with. This is fun (or alarming) the first time it happens and subsequently just an irritant; I would certainly recommend being gentle on the throttle in the monsoon. A larger concern, however, is the lack of a spare wheel — sometimes even a space-saver! What strongly impresses about the VF6 is the cabin comfort and ease of driving. I spent roughly 10 hours in the driver's seat, largely wadding through traffic, and felt no fatigue whatsoever at the end of the day. A fast-paced expressway driving stint revealed a few more details. At triple-digit speeds, the VF6 demonstrates seriously respectable stability, while its cabin continues to insulate you from road and tyre noise quite admirably. **WORK TO DO** Roughly 180 km of testing did reveal that I was, at best, in a position

to extract 320 km of range from it. That, however, I would attribute to my own driving style for the day. A mindful driver should be able to nudge the 400-km mark, if not more. Funnily enough, my share of range anxiety came not directly from the car itself but from my phone draining its battery out; the VF6 offers four USB-A charging ports which, I believe, went out of fashion in the 18th century. An unfunny concern, though, is the backseat. There simply isn't enough leg/knee room as compared to its peers and it's a real struggle if you're 5'10" or taller. The front seatbacks are made of a cruelly hard plastic that VinFast should replace quickly, seeing as it has access to greater materials otherwise. The boot, isn't large enough for a family of four and there's no storage space under the bonnet either (the Curvv.ev and Creta Electric have one). What also doesn't help is the glass roof which isn't offered with a retractable shade. Under a blazing Pune sun, this made the otherwise pleasant cabin experience needlessly uncomfortable. You can spec a top-variant without it, thankfully.

BE A SPORT You may have gathered by now that the VF6 is a car that's easy to like on most counts. But, seeing what its peers present in terms of stronger practicality, it's not as easy to recommend objectively, with fixed prices ranging between ₹17.29 lakh (Earth) and ₹19.19 lakh (Wind Infinity; ex-showroom, Delhi). Here's where I feel VinFast has missed a trick; it should simply have positioned the VF6 as a 'performance' car. Given its strong dynamics and its substantial power advantage, a racier packaging would have lent it a unique identity in a class dominated by sedate family-friendly SUVs. There sure is room for a sporty electric 2+2 seater with a snazzy paint scheme and interiors to match, wouldn't you agree? Where's the fun in playing on a level field anyway?

@The MotorGram

Ready to Raid

SERIOUSLY FUN. The KTM 390 Adventure R is the most hardcore of the range, and it's eager to take you places you've never been



Ruman Devmane

In its 14-year journey in India, KTM has so far made quite a few dreams accessible to riders. Most of our quests, whether they involve the streets, racetracks, trails or the open road, easily end at a KTM of some sort, typically flaunting the coveted '390' decal. With the 390 Adventure R, KTM aspires to fill yet another gap, offering a motorcycle that can unapologetically

plough through where the highway ends. The Adventure R works to a straightforward brief which, in all fairness, is an easy one for KTM; it knows exactly how to build bikes like these and it already had the parts lying around, to put it simply. Indeed, the 390 Adventure R is essentially an amalgamation of its travel-oriented Adventure and the singularly off-road-focused Enduro R. The result of this is an Adventure that's the tallest of its kind,

riding on 21-/18-inch tubed tyres (the range-topping S gets 21-/17-inch tubeless spokes; the X gets 19-/17-inch alloys), with the highest ground clearance (272 mm, up by 35-44 mm over the S/X), longest suspension travel (230 mm, up by 30/25 mm, front/rear) and also the tallest seat height (880 mm, up by 50-55 mm). It's nominally heavier than the rest, although on the move you'll struggle to notice that. What you will easily grasp is how much these numbers alter

the riding experience, especially if you've sampled the other Adventures in the lineup. Perched atop, you will find yourself looking over traffic — a rather liberating feeling — and off the road, it makes undulations seem far less intimidating. Fortunately, it has the hardware to keep up with the bravado it induces. **JOY RIDE** The adjustable suspension, sourced from the Enduro R (international spec), has more up its



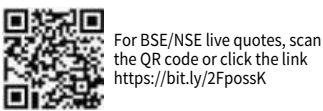
LOCKED AND LOADED. The impressive equipment list includes longer-travel adjustable suspension, a host of rider assists, increased ground clearance and an 18-inch rear wheel

sleeve than I could aim for, and the larger rear wheel enhances the control and stability it already offers a lot of. KTM's tube-tyre logic (it's got something to do with bending a rim and losing air rapidly in an extreme off-road scenario) for its off-road motorcycles is debatable, though. Most of us have to travel a fair bit to arrive at a trail and a puncture (I've had two on my own Enduro) can be a downright inconvenience that can make you wary of hitting the road altogether. Not a nice feeling, that! You'll forget about this when you're having fun with the R, though — and that's an easy place

to arrive at. I rode it for roughly 260 km, through a mixed cycle of urban, highway and off-road environments and found it to be thoroughly engaging. Contrary to what its specifications suggest — with its strong 45.3-bhp motor now being matched by superlative dimensions — it's not a particularly challenging motorcycle to get familiar with. KTM's approach to tractability, assisted by a bunch of rider aids (riding modes, traction control, disengageable ABS) and an inherently great hardware package (the fantastic 399 cc engine, terrific suspension, tyres and brakes) make the Adventure R easy to have fun

with and, while it's no beginner bike, upgrading to it once you feel confident enough will continue to feel rewarding for a long time. The properly committed riders amongst you will find it charming in how effortlessly it tackles off-road challenges. Its ₹3.77 lakh (ex-showroom, Delhi) price seats it squarely between the other two variants and, seeing as it undercuts the S by ₹17,000 while unlocking a higher degree of off-road functionality, it sure is a tempting buy. Just make sure you know how to fix a puncture all by yourself, okay?

@The MotorGram



For BSE/NSE live quotes, scan the QR code or click the link
<https://bit.ly/2fpossk>

QUICKLY.

Adobe shares drop as CEO steps down



Adobe's battered shares fell another 6 per cent on Friday as news that the Photoshop maker's long-time CEO would step down cast fresh doubts over its strategy to battle mounting AI competition. Shantanu Narayen is credited with crafting the modern Adobe by turning its creative tools into a subscription service with more reliable revenue. But an influx of AI rivals that can create images at low cost and with a simple text prompt has in recent years raised doubts about its position. Analysts said the lack of clarity fanned investor fears. REUTERS

Innovision extends IPO deadline to March 17

New Delhi: Manpower and toll plaza management services provider Innovision extended the closing date of its initial public offering (IPO) to March 17 and reduced the price band, following a lukewarm response from investors. The IPO, which opened for subscription on March 10, was earlier scheduled to close on March 12. The company has now revised the price band to ₹494-519 per share, lower than the earlier band of ₹521-548 per share, an update with the stock exchange showed. The new price band would be effective from March 13, it added. Investor participation remained subdued during the first three days of the issue. As of the third day, the IPO was subscribed 32 per cent overall, according to data available with the NSE. PTI

BROKER'S CALL.

ICICI Securities

HDB FINANCIAL (BUY)

Target: ₹900
CMP: ₹642.25
HDB Financial Services (HDBFS) — a blue-chip heritage paired with a formidable low-cost borrowing moat. The combination bestows an inherent advantage upon the company to command sustainable, scalable and high-margin growth. Notably, HDBFS has been strategically firming up an asset franchise stronghold (over ₹1 lakh crore, as of FY25) in India's underserved hinterlands (about 70 per cent) branches in tier-4+ locations). Separately, despite macroeconomic headwinds, it delivered a over 20 per cent AUM CAGR (FY14-25), bolstering its leading NBFC status. A decadal around 2 per cent credit cost average is testament to HDBFS' cycle-tested underwriting and risk-management protocols. HDBFS' focus on direct customer sourcing—accounts for over 80 per cent of FY25 disbursements—facilitates customer quality and operational efficiency. We initiate coverage at Buy and a TP of ₹900, basis 3x Sep'27E BVPS.
Key risks: Delayed Management expects growth to exceed nominal GDP by 6–7 per cent in near-term. While positive trends in CV volumes suggest that HDBFS is well-positioned to benefit from a CV upcycle, the company faces risks from market share loss and overall sluggishness in the CV segment; HDBFS operates in highly competitive segments like LAP, CV and gold. Most of these segments are currently witnessing intense competition from banks; and AI disruption may lead to higher unemployment (especially in IT sector) and part of its consumer finance business is directly exposed to the salaried segment.

Geojit Research

MUTHOOT FINANCE (HOLD)

Target: ₹3,478
CMP: ₹3,332.95
Muthoot Finance Ltd, India's largest NBFC in gold loans by loan portfolio, operates over 7,541 branches nationwide. Besides gold loans, it offers various loans, insurance, money transfer services, and gold coin sales through its subsidiaries. Gold loan yield stood at 20.34 per cent in Q3FY26, supported by one-off NPA recoveries. On a normalized basis, yields are expected to remain in the 18.5-19 per cent range. Meanwhile, management has raised FY26 gold loan growth guidance to 45 per cent. We maintain a cautious outlook on Muthoot Finance despite its strong Q3FY26 performance, where results exceeded estimates, supported by record profit growth and continued AUM expansion. However, the stock has recently faced pressure amid volatility in gold prices and a slight decline in gold collateral tonnage. Additionally, the stock is currently trading at a historical premium to its long-term average, indicating that the recent price correction has already factored in much of the quarterly positives. Nevertheless, improving visibility in loan book growth and stabilising asset quality remain supportive. Considering these factors, we upgrade our rating to Hold with a revised target price of ₹3,478, based on 2.4x FY28E BVPS.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

US, Europe stocks waver as investors weigh data, geopolitical tensions

UNDER PRESSURE. Europe's STOXX 600 slips 0.13%, with the index on track for a more than 5% fall in March

Reuters

Global stocks were mixed and crude oil prices stayed elevated as uncertainty over the Iran war continues to disrupt energy supplies, driving concerns over fuel inflation and interest rates. The price of oil hovered around \$100 per barrel even as an Indian tanker sailed out of the Strait of Hormuz and the US put forth measures to try and ease supply concerns.

OIL ON BOIL

Crude oil prices remain more than a third higher than when the United States and Israel launched strikes on Iran almost two weeks ago.

President Donald Trump said the US was going to be hitting Iran "very hard over the next week", shortly after

issuing a partial 30-day waiver for purchases of sanctioned Russian oil, hoping to ease prices fuelled by the US-Israeli war on Iran.

On Wall Street, the Dow Jones Industrial Average rose 0.3 per cent, the S&P 500 was little changed, and the Nasdaq Composite dipped about 0.1 per cent.

"It could simply be the case we've had two if not three days of pretty aggressive selling across the board, and there's simply a degree of exhaustion coming in," said Michael Brown, senior research strategist at Pepperstone.

"Crude benchmark is a touch softer, and everything on the whole is still taking its lead from where oil is trading," he said.

Europe's STOXX 600 dropped 0.13 per cent, with the index on track for a more



MIXED TREND. While the Dow Jones Industrial Average rose 0.3 per cent, the S&P 500 was little changed and the Nasdaq dipped about 0.1 per cent in early deals on Friday REUTERS

than 5 per cent fall in March so far, its biggest two-week decline in a year.

MSCI's gauge of stocks across the globe fell 0.3 per cent.

Meanwhile, the dollar has become the safe-haven of

choice during the tumult, putting most other currencies under pressure.

DOLLAR SHINES

The US currency was set for a second consecutive week of gains, up 0.5 per cent on the

Coal India arm CMPDIL to launch IPO on March 20

Our Bureau
Kolkata

State-run Coal India Limited's wholly owned subsidiary Central Mine Planning and Design Institute Limited (CMPDIL), which has filed a Red Herring Prospectus (RHP) with capital markets regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) for its proposed initial public offering (IPO), plans to open the issue for subscription on March 20.

The public issue, entirely an offer for sale (OFS) of 10.71 crore shares by Coal India with no fresh issue component, will close on March 24. CMPDIL had

earlier filed draft papers with SEBI in May last year for the IPO.

NON-COAL SUBSIDIARY

CMPDIL was set up to prepare perspective plans, provide consultancy services, and undertake exploration and drilling to establish coal reserves, besides generating detailed data for mining projects.

"The promoter selling shareholder will be entitled to the entire proceeds of the offer after deducting its share of offer expenses and applicable taxes. Our company will not receive any proceeds from the offer," CMPDIL said in the RHP. The company said the ob-

MFs intra-day borrowings capped at 20% of net assets

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Capital markets regulator SEBI has introduced a new framework allowing mutual funds to borrow to meet redemption needs in debt schemes, equity-oriented index funds and equity ETFs.

The borrowing limit has been capped at 20 per cent of a scheme's net assets, with the tenure of borrowings restricted to six months. The new rules will come into effect from April 1.

Mutual funds are currently allowed to borrow mainly to meet redemptions in liquid and overnight schemes, as these are processed in the morning of T+1, while maturity proceeds from TREPES and reverse repo are received only in the evening of T+1.

To bridge this intra-day timing mismatch between inflows and outflows, mutual funds enter into formal intra-day borrowing arrangements with banks.

This facility has now been extended to equity-oriented index funds and equity ETFs. However, mutual funds may breach the 20 per cent intra-day borrowing limit only with board approval, the SEBI said in a circular on Friday.

BORROWING POLICY

The policy for use of intra-day borrowing facilities will be approved by the board of AMC and board of trustees and will be uploaded on the AMC's website. Intra-day borrowings will be used only for repurchase/redemption of units or payment of interest/income distribution-cum-capital withdrawal payout to the unitholders.

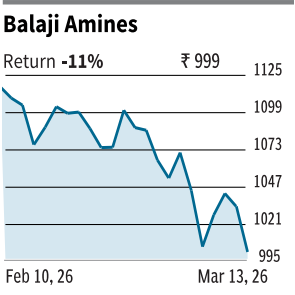
The amount of intra-day borrowings will not exceed the guaranteed receivables due on the same day from the government, the RBI and the Clearing Corporation of India. The cost will be borne by the AMC. Further, any loss or cost incurred will be borne by the AMC, said the circular.

Balaji Amines feels the heat as W. Asia conflict disrupts ammonia supply

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Shares of Balaji Amines fell sharply on the National Stock Exchange on Friday amid concerns over supply disruptions triggered by the ongoing West Asia conflict.

The stock opened lower at ₹999 compared with the previous close of ₹1,035 and extended losses to touch an intra-day low of ₹989, marking a decline of 4.4 per cent from previous day's price. The stock, however, managed to recover a bit to close at ₹1,000.90, down 3.3 per cent



from the previous day's close.

The company informed the stock exchanges that it is facing severe logistical disruptions in procuring ammonia, a key raw material, due to

escalating geopolitical tensions in West Asia.

WAR IMPACT

The disruption has also affected the supply of Liquefied Natural Gas, a critical input used in ammonia production.

The company said the situation has directly impacted its ammonia procurement, which is essential for manufacturing methylamines, ethylamines and their derivatives. Balaji Amines further said that the financial and operational impact of the disruption cannot be assessed at this stage.

Rival NSE's listing, a possible advantage for BSE

RINGSIDE VIEW.



KS BADRI NARAYANAN

The National Stock Exchange (NSE) has begun the IPO process in earnest. With the appointment of investment bankers and law firms, the listing process is expected to gather pace. However, the timing will depend on the secondary market conditions. If the current bear phase persists, the NSE may wait for more favourable market conditions. In January, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) issued a no-objection certificate (NOC) for the proposed initial public offering (IPO) of the National Stock Exchange (NSE). This cleared a major regulatory hurdle that had kept the country's largest stock exchange from accessing the public markets for nearly a decade, following challenges, including the dark fibre co-location scam and other regulatory issues. A few days ago, the Delhi High Court dismissed a petition challenging the NOC for the IPO, paving the way for the exchange's public issue. Soon after, the NSE moved to advance the listing process.

IPO SIZE

The IPO will be purely an offer-for-sale, allowing existing shareholders to dilute a portion of their holdings, while the NSE itself will continue operating without balance sheet infusion. Going by media buzz, the exchange plans to launch ₹24,000-₹25,000 crore IPO, which would rank among India's largest public issues.

The listing of India's most active exchange will benefit Asia's oldest exchange—the BSE, which lost to the NSE in volume games for the last two decades. As per current regulations, the NSE can be listed only on the BSE and the Metropolitan Stock Exchange of India; self listing is not permitted.

The regulatory framework governing Market Infrastructure Institutions (MIIs) has been undergoing several revisions following their transition into corporate entities and demutual-



LISTING NORMS. As per current regulations, the NSE can be listed only on the BSE and the Metropolitan Stock Exchange of India; self listing is not allowed

ised structures. The move to corporatise and demutualise stock exchanges was first proposed in the 2002-03 Budget, aiming to transform them from not-for-profit, member-owned bodies into for-profit corporate entities, while separating ownership from trading rights and paving the way for them to operate as publicly listed companies.

COMPARISON

BSE turned into a public limited company on August 8, 2005, and hit the capital market in January 2017. With the

NOC now in hand, the NSE is expected to take about 8-9 months to launch the offering. Currently, its rivals BSE and MCX are already listed. The listing could help the BSE retain its marginal lead over the NSE in terms of market capitalisation. Currently, the market capitalisation of companies listed on the BSE stands about ₹430 lakh crore (\$4.6 trillion), compared with ₹428 lakh crore (\$4.7 trillion) on the NSE. These figures fluctuate frequently amid market volatility, often altering the relative positions of the two

exchanges. Analysts estimate that the NSE could command a market capitalisation of around ₹4 lakh crore upon listing, which may allow the BSE to maintain its lead on this metric.

According to latest shareholding data, the NSE has nearly 1.86 lakh retail shareholders, making it the largest unlisted company in terms of retail investor participation. Since its shares will be traded on the BSE, the listing will boost the latter's trading volumes and, in turn, its fee-based revenue. Besides, the NSE will feature in the BSE's major indices. Mutual funds that track these indices will need to buy NSE shares, potentially raising institutional trading activity on the BSE. As a listed entity, the NSE will also be required to disclose all corporate developments and price-sensitive information to the BSE, enhancing transparency around the country's premier exchange.

Overall, the NSE listing will be closely watched by investors and competitors alike. Interesting days lie ahead for India's exchange landscape.

India's listed REIT market up 6x since FY20 to ₹1,72,600 cr

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

India's listed REIT market has expanded more than six-fold since FY20, growing from ₹27,100 crore to ₹1,72,600 crore in the first nine months of FY26, according to a report by CBRE Group. The surge has been driven by fresh listings and rising unit prices. India now has five listed REITs, with Knowledge Realty Trust the latest entrant in August 2025.

The other four REITs recorded over 20 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) unit price growth between Q3 FY25 and Q3 FY26. Embassy REIT grew 18 per cent y-o-y, Mindspare Business Parks REIT rose 31 per cent, Brookfield REIT climbed 21 per cent and Nexus Select Trust gained 14 per cent. "India's REIT market has delivered consistent

returns to investors through a volatile global cycle," said Anshuman Magazine, Chairman and CEO, India, South-East Asia, Middle East and Africa, CBRE. "The listing of these instruments can provide flexible exit options for key investors, potentially driving a wave of institutional participation and deepening market liquidity. The structural reforms now taking shape are likely to significantly expand the segment's investor base in the coming years."

Rami Kaushal, Managing Director, Consulting & Valuation Services — India, Middle East & Africa, CBRE, said the evolving regulatory framework is expected to enable broader equity market participation and lower the cost of capital for REIT platforms, accelerating portfolio expansion and new listings.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 488.05 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Hind Unilever	2160.00	4.50	50.47	1.82	
TataConsumerProduct	1083.60	3.69	72.87	0.76	
Bharti Airtel	1003.40	1.28	27.75	4.67	
Apollo Hosp	7550.00	-0.55	58.18	0.74	
Cipla	1314.70	-1.18	23.43	0.70	
Coal India	467.00	-1.54	9.67	1.00	
Trent Ltd.	3487.80	-2.23	76.54	0.73	
Adani Enter	1961.10	-2.34	16.02	0.48	
Tech Mahindra	1332.80	-2.37	28.44	0.80	
Asian Paints	2196.80	-2.42	53.58	0.94	
PowerGrid Corp	390.95	-2.63	18.03	1.29	
NestleIndia	1202.20	-2.93	71.08	0.82	
Wipro	197.58	-3.09	15.54	0.53	
SBI Life	1904.40	-3.45	77.03	0.81	
Dr Reddys Lab	1292.30	-3.57	19.53	0.75	
Bajaj Finserv	1738.00	-4.11	14.46	0.94	
Adani Ports	1363.20	-4.58	25.13	0.95	
Int'lCobavi	4158.20	-4.64	50.07	0.89	
Bajaj Finance	855.05	-4.69	29.03	2.15	
HDFC Life	625.75	-4.70	71.43	0.64	
Tata Motors PV	314.10	-4.79	42.71	0.62	
Max Healthcare	990.00	-4.96	67.86	0.70	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	292.30	-5.08	93.13	0.95	
Titan	4073.20	-5.11	75.87	1.59	
ONGC	264.10	-5.50	7.39	0.97	
Sun Pharma	1801.60	-5.51	39.47	1.81	
ITC	301.45	-5.60	18.24	2.75	
NTPC	384.45	-6.34	15.01	1.73	
Bajaj Auto	8875.00	-6.38	27.90	0.93	
Eicher Motors	6741.00	-7.08	34.51	0.88	
TCS	2410.50	-7.15	18.18	2.33	
HCL Tech	1325.40	-7.57	21.84	1.33	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1003.60	-8.63	20.64	1.33	
Eternal Ltd.	215.68	-8.65	901.03	1.47	
Graiss Ind	2568.60	-8.76	18.46	0.93	
SJS Steel	1119.30	-10.07	34.51	1.00	
Bharat Elec	439.10	-11.32	53.86	1.49	
Maruti Suzuki	12591.00	-12.09	26.51	1.57	
UltraTech Cement	10616.00	-12.30	40.82	1.19	
Infosys	1248.30	-13.45	18.07	1.41	
Kotak Bank	366.85	-13.63	19.41	2.56	
Reliance Ind	1465.70	-13.06	25.02	1.24	
Tata Steel	1183.51	-18.06	25.11	1.44	
ICICI Bank	1254.80	-18.33	15.85	8.49	
Hindalco	910.05	-18.95	12.72	1.25	
M&M	2931.10	-19.60	21.56	2.44	
Axis Bank	1197.10	-23.39	14.07	3.25	
State Bank	1047.00	-34.77	11.17	4.12	
HDRC Bank	52.85	-38.61	16.23	1.94	
L&T	3439.00	-72.27	24.93	3.83	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▼ 1,733.10 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Hyundai Motor India	2018.00	9.97	28.32	1.33	
Britannia Ind	5808.50	7.61	57.90	3.18	
Macrotech Developers	866.35	-2.28	25.86	1.13	
Abi India	6392.50	-2.60	80.33	1.55	
Info Edge I	852.40	-3.50	36.65	1.72	
Bajaj Housing Finance	82.15	-4.30	27.63	0.36	
AdaniGreenenergy	861.35	-4.78	76.44	1.22	
Zyduslisciences	905.90	-8.26	18.14	1.05	
Jsw Energy	512.95	-8.61	34.44	1.28	
Adani Energy Solutions	992.30	-12.59	50.01	1.60	
ICI Lombard Gic	1837.10	-13.22	33.45	2.06	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	97.20	-14.58	18.13	0.81	
Cholamandalam&Fin	1514.00	-15.35	26.36	2.97	
Lic	772.70	-15.95	9.22	8.00	
Torrent Pharma	4390.00	-17.57	65.40	2.13	
Siemens Energy India	2796.90	-18.57	84.32	1.15	
Solar Industries	14251.00	-20.03	84.47	1.61	
Shree Cement	22965.00	-21.47	46.13	1.42	
Mazagon Dock	2328.00	-26.28	39.02	0.82	
Bosch	30185.00	-29.15	32.29	1.21	
Godrej Consumer	1027.90	-29.46	57.74	1.92	
Df	542.75	-29.54	30.34	1.61	
Adani Power	1465.70	-30.06	25.02	2.68	
Siemens	3207.60	-31.05	72.05	1.31	
Lmtindtree	4206.50	-32.58	26.40	1.81	
Havells	1310.20	-33.14	55.42	1.53	
Tata Power	394.95	-36.28	25.20	3.08	
Bajaj Holdings	9506.00	-36.76	11.80	1.91	
Gail (India)	147.78	-36.98	11.29	1.85	
Ambuja Cements	425.35	-38.61	21.36	3.20	
Indian Hotels Co.	609.85	-39.79	40.11	2.48	
Varun Beverages	401.30	-40.03	44.32	2.55	
Hindus Zinc	551.95	-40.38	19.76	1.11	
Indian OilCorp	156.54	-40.58	6.00	2.71	
Bpcl	319.30	-41.00	5.63	2.87	
United Spirits	1314.40	-42.35	55.58	1.80	
Pidlindt	1340.00	-44.16	58.93	1.93	
Rural Elec	331.50	-44.97	5.06	1.92	
Power Finance	405.60	-45.00	4.01	2.74	
Bank Of Baroda	281.05	-45.36	7.40	2.42	
Punjab Natl Bank	111.70	-50.79	7.18	1.79	
AvenueSuper	499.30	-52.70	87.13	2.66	
Hindustanaraonatics	3914.40	-56.61	29.43	3.44	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	709.90	-56.45	100.77	2.26	
Canara Bank	134.68	-57.25	6.63	2.11	
Tvs Motor Cmp.	3324.50	-69.11	51.72	3.62	
Divis Lab	6071.00	-80.44	65.01	3.58	
Samvardandhotentinternational	11382	-84.61	33.01	2.94	
Jindal Steel	1143.30	-85.69	59.07	2.96	
Vedanta	689.55	-152.95	16.27	5.43	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Dry run

IMD needs to provide realistic assessment on El Nino

Even as analysts are still working out the implications of the Iran conflict on the economy, trouble seems to be brewing on another front — the upcoming monsoon. Global weather watchers are now forecasting a likely re-emergence of El Nino this year. World Meteorological Organisation in its early March update said that fading La Nina conditions could morph into a warming El Nino episode by May to July with a 40 per cent probability.



The recent European Centre for Medium Term Weather Forecasts prediction is more direct, with a 22 per cent chance of a ‘super’ El Nino, an 80 per cent chance of a strong one and 98 per cent chance of a moderate event this year. Should such forecasts come good, the Indian economy could face headwinds on both growth and inflation, calling for policy vigilance. To be sure, there have been false alarms on El Nino in recent years. El Nino events can also vary in severity and not all of them adversely impact India’s agricultural output. Offsetting factors such as the Indian Ocean Dipole can blunt its impact on the monsoon. Nevertheless, it is hard to ignore that 10 of the 15 drought years in India since 1950, were brought on by El Nino. Moderate to strong El Nino years saw rainfall fall short of LPA (Long-Period Average) by 14-15 per cent. This led to a 1-2 percentage point contraction in the agriculture leg of GVA (Gross Value Added) in those years. Recent official estimates peg the growth in Agriculture GVA at just 2.4 per cent for FY26. A second consecutive year of poor growth can dent rural employment and incomes. Moderate/strong El Nino years have also sparked food inflation, due to kharif output declining by between 6 and 12 per cent. This is a worry, as RBI’s forecasts already expect consumer price inflation to rise to 4 and 4.2 per cent in the first two quarters of FY27, without budgeting for El Nino. In recent years, the government has attempted to address food shortages and inflationary trends set off by El Nino through post-facto interventions. It has undertaken releases of foodgrain stocks from Central buffers, banned exports and opened the floodgates of imports on agri-commodities in short supply. But such interventions carry a price. Ad-hoc export bans and import duty cuts hit realisations for farmers, who are already engaged in a risky occupation. This makes it critical to get a hold on the strength and timing of the upcoming El Nino ahead of the kharif sowing season. This will enable proactive policy choices on trade, sowing decisions and water conservation. It is important that the India Meteorological Department (IMD) makes a realistic assessment of the likelihood and severity of El Nino in its April monsoon forecast. Experience shows that it tends to underplay the El Nino impact. In the El Nino years 2018 and 2023, IMD forecasted normal monsoons with rainfall at 97 and 96 per cent of LPA. However, actual monsoon performance turned out much worse, with rainfall at 91 and 94 per cent of LPA. More accuracy is called for here.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

Trump’s war on Iran: the world’s poor will pay dearly
Soaring prices at the pump, the scrapping of mortgage deals, and the prospect of higher prices for everything from food to smartphones. The US-Israeli attack on Iran, and Tehran’s retaliation, has rocked the global economy. Consumers are already feeling the pain of the biggest energy supply shock in history, and Iran’s new supreme leader, Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, vowed on Thursday that the strait of Hormuz will remain closed, according to a statement attributed to him by state media. The corridor is the biggest chokepoint for the global energy system. The relief to oil prices brought by the International Energy Agency’s largest ever release of reserves had already proved shortlived: as the US and Israel intensified attacks on Iran, it escalated attacks on transport infrastructure across the Gulf. But the impact is not evenly felt. And it is the world’s poorest and most vulnerable who will be worst hit. LONDON, MARCH 12

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Keeping Up With the Jones Act

The Trump Administration is looking for ways to mitigate rising U.S. gasoline prices caused by the war. That includes suspending the 1920 Jones Act, and ponder that irony: Because of a war, the President may suspend a law that was intended to protect national security. As Iran escalated its attacks on oil tankers and infrastructure in the region, White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt said Thursday that “in the interest of national defense, the White House is considering waiving the Jones Act for a limited period of time to ensure vital energy products and agricultural necessities are flowing freely to U.S. ports.” Hear, hear. NEW YORK, MARCH 12



DESMOND LACHMAN

Until recently, one of the MAGA movement’s most deeply held convictions was that American blood and treasure should not be expended abroad when Americans — and the American Dream — are suffering at home. Yet now the movement’s leader, President Donald Trump, has rushed headlong into a costly war against Iran. The US-Israeli campaign against the Islamic Republic is bound to put a considerable dent in the US budget at a time when the country’s public finances already are on an unsustainable path. It is also bound to continue pushing up international oil and gas prices at a time when the US already has an affordability problem. Neither outcome bodes well for US inflation and employment, with the outlook already grim following an unexpectedly negative monthly jobs report. Even before the start of the Iran war, Trump suggested that the US needed a substantial expansion of its defence budget, proposing to increase it by \$500 billion per year from its current level of \$1 trillion. Now that the US is engaged in a full-scale war that could drag on indefinitely and upend the world’s geopolitical map, Trump’s case for a significant increase in defence spending would seem to have grown even stronger. Of course, it is too early to gauge the direct costs of the war, since nobody knows how long and intensive it will be. But we do know that it is currently costing around \$1 billion per day. The bill for the month-long conflict that Trump is anticipating therefore would approach \$50 billion, with the costs continuing to rise the longer the war continues. Beyond the direct costs of replacing US ammunition and equipment, there will be other reasons for augmenting the defence budget. For starters, the Pentagon may need to prepare for a scenario in which the entire Middle East is destabilised, especially if the Trump administration follows through on arming the Iranian Kurds, which will antagonise Turkey and perhaps incite other separatist movements within Iran. Second, with America’s attention diverted, Russia and China could see an opportunity to press their claims in Ukraine and Taiwan, respectively, demanding even greater US military spending to maintain deterrence.

Can US afford Trump’s Iran war?

PERILOUS PATH. It will considerably dent the US budget at a time when the country’s public finances are unsustainable



VIA REUTERS

NO FREE LUNCHES

As the Nobel laureate economist Milton Friedman was fond of saying, there is no such thing as a free lunch. Nowhere is this maxim more aptly applied than to military interventions. The wars in Vietnam, Iraq, and Afghanistan all demonstrated that the US is not good at choosing between guns and butter. It always seems to want both, even though pursuing both risks generating inflationary pressure. This is an especially relevant concern today. According to the Congressional Budget Office, the US can expect to run budget deficits exceeding 6 per cent of GDP as far as the eye can see. That means it is on track to exceed the

Normally, when geopolitical tensions are heightened, investors rush towards the safety of US Treasuries. But foreign investors might be losing their appetite for US debt; bond yields have been rising since the start of the war

debt-to-GDP ratio at the end of World War II.

The Trump administration may not care about America’s deteriorating public finances, but bond markets certainly do. Normally when geopolitical tensions are heightened, international investors rush towards the safety of US Treasuries. But in yet another sign that foreign investors might be losing their appetite for US debt, bond yields have been rising since the start of the Iran war. With the US government financing a \$2 trillion budget deficit and rolling over around \$9 trillion in maturing bonds this year, a loss of foreign appetite for its debt is the last thing it needs. The US also is in no position to absorb an energy-price shock. But that is what seems to be in store. In its fight for survival, the Iranian regime is desperately trying to export the war to its Gulf neighbours and disrupt shipping in the Strait of Hormuz, through which 20 per cent of the world’s oil supply passes. On March 4, Goldman Sachs estimated that a five-week closure of this crucial waterway could send oil prices over \$100 per barrel. In fact, that threshold has now already been breached.

OIL PRICE WORRIES

Even though the US economy is far less dependent on oil imports than it was during previous energy-price surges, it certainly would not be immune to a near doubling of the oil price since the start of the year. The International Monetary Fund estimates that, “If energy prices sustain just a 10 per cent increase over a period of one year, this would add 0.4 percentage point to inflation and slow economic growth by 0.1-0.2 per cent” globally. Such stagflationary effects would further compound an already difficult budget situation by reducing tax revenues. The political strategist James Carville famously said that when it comes to winning elections, the economy is everything. If he is still right, a prolonged Iranian war could spell real trouble for Trump’s Republicans in November’s midterms. If the US does get a combination of a bond-market crisis, higher inflation, and an economic slowdown, Trump and his party may come to regret their betrayal of the “America First” agenda.

The writer is a senior fellow at the American Enterprise Institute, and a former deputy director of the IMF’s. Copyright: Project Syndicate, 2026

Effective futures markets can lift farm fortunes

Transparent warehousing, integrated spot markets, predictable stock policies, and reduced ad-hoc interventions are essential

Lalit Patil Bahale

India’s debate on agricultural futures markets has long been framed as a clash between two characters: the speculative trader and the vulnerable farmer. It is an evocative narrative, but it prevents us from asking deeper questions. Instead of examining how institutions, incentives, and policies interact, we reduce a complex economic system into a moral judgment. If India aims for agricultural modernity, perhaps the more relevant question is this: can we build a credible system of price discovery while simultaneously using discretionary administrative control to influence those same prices? And if not, what must change? Understanding the role of futures markets becomes essential in this inquiry. At their core, futures markets help manage price risk by allowing farmers and businesses to lock in prices ahead of time. In reality, they serve three critical functions — discovering future prices, transferring risk through hedging, and coordinating inventory movements over time. But these functions work well only when prices reflect actual supply and demand conditions. This is where India faces its biggest challenge. The policy environment surrounding agriculture is full of interventions that seek to stabilise prices or protect farmers, but often these interventions unintentionally disrupt the very price signals that markets rely on. Sudden stock limits under the

Essential Commodities Act, unpredictable import-export controls, selective execution of Minimum Support Prices, fragmented APMC markets, and land ceiling restrictions all play a role. Each policy was created with specific objectives, yet together they create a system where markets are asked to function freely but are frequently overridden. Can markets be expected to reveal economic truth while policy retains the authority to reinterpret it? And if both systems continue side by side, how do we manage the distortions that arise? The consequences become clearer when we examine specific examples. Consider storage. If stock-holding is periodically restricted or penalised, private investment in warehousing naturally shrinks. Without adequate storage, post-harvest prices fall sharply, and prices during lean seasons rise sharply. Futures markets, which rely on stable storage costs to forecast future prices, lose their foundation. The result is not stability but uncertainty. **ANOTHER LAYER OF FRICTION** A similar contradiction arises with MSP. When MSP is presented as a universal guarantee, expectations rise. Yet MSP procurement is limited by geography, crop type, and State capacity. When the government cannot purchase all produce at MSP, farmers are left exposed. Futures markets could have helped them hedge against price dips, but without clear signals or consistent policy, they cannot participate effectively. APMC markets add another layer of



FARMERS. Will benefit from clear price signals VUJAYA KUMAR T

friction. Because many physical markets are poorly connected, price information travels slowly. Arbitrage, which normally brings spot prices and futures prices into alignment, becomes difficult. Futures markets depend on strong linkages between physical markets and derivative markets; without them, price discovery weakens. Consider land ceiling laws that keep farms fragmented. Small and scattered landholdings make it harder for farmers to store produce, engage in hedging, or access affordable credit. Without collective structures like farmer-producer organisations, participating in futures markets remains logistically challenging. This raises an important question: how can farmers exercise economic sovereignty if they lack the scale and tools to protect their incomes? Given these structural gaps, suspending futures markets may seem like a protective measure, but does it

address the root causes of price volatility? Or does it remove one of the few instruments that allow farmers to manage risk? When policy shifts frequently — whether through commodity suspensions, stock limits, or export bans — the result is not stability but hesitation across the system. Consistency, not interruption, is what ultimately curbs manipulation and builds trust. If India wants futures markets to function effectively, the surrounding ecosystem must be strengthened. Transparent warehousing, integrated spot markets, predictable stock policies, and reduced ad-hoc interventions are essential. Equally important is enabling farmers to participate meaningfully by supporting farmer-producer organisations, improving financial literacy, and creating pathways for risk management. When farmers are given modern tools, rather than being shielded from them, they can act as informed economic agents. The goal is not to remove the state but to bring coherence to policy, clarity to markets, and confidence to participants. India stands at a crossroads. If we aspire to agricultural leadership, we must decide whether to continue with contradictory systems that restrict the flow of price signals, or to build a transparent, modern, and trusted agricultural market architecture. The path to sovereignty lies not in supervision but in empowerment — and in trusting both our institutions and our farmers to move forward together.

The writer is President of Shetakari Sanghatana

LETTERS TO EDITOR

Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Easing of FDI rules

This refers to 'China positive' (March 13). The government's recent decision to relax FDI rules for neighbouring countries by allowing minority investments through automatic routes is indeed a positive move but it has started a debate. This clear policy shift reflects a balancing act between safeguarding economic interests and encouraging a more open investment environment. There is no doubt that easing restrictions will attract much needed capital, support the growth of Indian industries and strengthen

economic ties. But it has to be implemented with clear safeguards and accountability as our strategic interests and data security should not be compromised at any cost. **Bal Govind** Noida **Strive for peace** Factors like animosity among neighbours and long-standing conflicts are the root causes of acts of terror. The lack of vision and far-sighted actions and the dearth of great minds have led to regional conflicts that have long been raging

across the world. Economic slumps, unemployment and uneven growth have turned out to be bigger issues. The leaders should understand these chronic issues and take urgent steps to resolve them. It's time to walk towards a world of peace and prosperity. **P Senthil Saravana Durai** Mumbai **Pursue diplomacy** Instead of taking concerted steps to de-escalate the military conflict with Iran through dialogue and diplomacy, Donald Trump and Benjamin

Netanyahu appear to be persisting with relentless bombardment. Iran, for its part, continues retaliatory strikes targeting US military bases and assets in Gulf states, signalling that the conflict may not end soon. The war is already triggering massive disruptions in global oil supply and sending energy prices soaring, with serious repercussions for the global economy. **M Jeyaram** Sholavandan, TN **FSSAI mandate** This refers to 'FSSAI mandates

registration of milk producers, vendors' (March 13). Though belated, this is a welcome move that will help ensure milk quality and prevent adulteration. The reason for exempting milk producers registered with dairy co-op societies is questionable though, as FSSAI is a regulatory body whereas co-op societies are not. Importantly, FSSAI must undertake random visits to milk production outlets as a measure to curb malpractices as well as to ensure hygienic practices. **Rajiv Magal** Halekere Village, Karnataka

QUICKLY.

**Forex reserves drop
\$11.68 b to \$716.81 b**

Mumbai: India's forex reserves dropped by \$11.683 billion to \$716.810 billion during the week ended March 6, the RBI said on Friday. In the previous reporting week, the overall reserves had increased by \$4.885 billion to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion. [PTI](#)

**Aurionpro gets ₹350 cr
deal to set up data centre**

Mumbai: Enterprise technology infrastructure provider Aurionpro Solutions on Friday said it has secured a multi-year contract worth close to ₹350 crore from a hyperscale operator for setting up a data centre in southern India. The engagement covers comprehensive design, detailed engineering, and end-to-end execution of MEP (mechanical, electrical and plumbing) works, Aurionpro said. [PTI](#)

Tractor sales jump a robust 34% in Feb, exports rise 7%

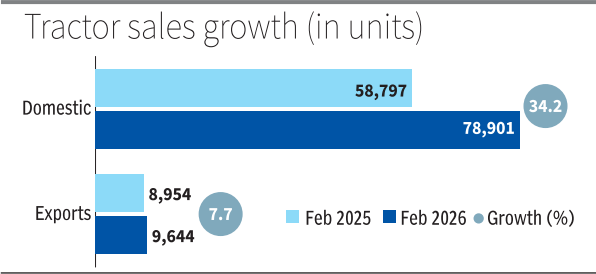
KEY DRIVERS. Growth attributed to strong rural sentiment, improved farm economics

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Domestic tractor sales grew sharply by 34 per cent year-on-year in February, while exports rose by 7 per cent, according to data released by the Tractor and Mechanization Association of India (TMA).

The industry recorded domestic sales of 78,901 units in February 2026, compared with 58,797 units in February 2025. Export shipments increased to 9,644 units from 8,954 units during the same period.

Industry players attribute the growth to strong rural sentiment and improved farm economics. A robust rabi sowing area, healthy



Source: Tractor and Mechanization Association of India

reservoir levels and a favourable kharif harvest have strengthened cash flows in rural markets. Positive sentiment in rural areas, coupled with Navratri-related seasonal demand, is expected to further support tractor sales in the coming months.

GST RATE CUT
Poonam Upadhyay, Director

at Crisil Ratings, said that the demand surge continues to be supported by the GST rate cut implemented last September, which improved affordability and triggered purchases from both first-time buyers and replacement demand.

However, with domestic sales already running at a high base, sequential norm-



alisation is visible, with volumes declining 10-11 per cent month-on-month, which is typical for the season, she said.

“Overall demand momentum is expected to remain steady, though on a very high base. The emerging El Nino probability will also be a factor to watch,” she added.

Ownly launch signals Rapido’s food delivery push amid \$600 m fundraise

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

Urban mobility start-up Rapido is stepping into the crowded food delivery market with the launch of Ownly, signalling a broader strategy beyond zero-commission meals as the company builds additional revenue streams alongside ride-hailing and logistics.

The move comes as Rapido is in the midst of raising \$550-600 million in a fresh funding round led by Prosus, with participation from Accel's India arm and existing investor WestBridge Capital. The transaction includes both primary and secondary components and is expected to strengthen the company's balance sheet as it expands into new verticals.

Rapido's food delivery service, Ownly, is being positioned as a platform that works closely with restaur-

ant partners while keeping commissions low. The company has begun rolling out the service in Bengaluru and plans to expand to more cities over time, people aware of the plans said.

“The fundraising is happening at a time when Ownly is looking to enter the market and expand to other cities. Though the competition is stiff, both Eternal and Swiggy are seeing positive outcomes from their food delivery businesses,” said an investor familiar with the development, requesting anonymity.

MARKET LEADERS

Food delivery remains a fiercely contested segment in India's consumer internet ecosystem. Market leaders Swiggy and Eternal, the parent of Zomato, have doubled down on the vertical in recent quarters, introducing new formats and operational tweaks aimed at improving

efficiency and order volumes.

Both companies have also reported improving unit economics in the segment, helped by higher order frequency, subscription-led loyalty programmes and experiments with quick food delivery formats.

Rapido's entry, however, comes with a different approach. The company is not looking to rely heavily on deep discounting in the early stages and instead plans to build supply through partnerships with restaurants while leveraging its existing rider network.

Another investor said capturing meaningful market share from entrenched players will take time. “Even though Ownly currently does not want to discount heavily and is relying on restaurant partnerships, it will be a difficult journey to take share from incumbents,” the investor said.

CII releases coffee table book on Tamil Nadu CEOs

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) has come out with a Tamil Nadu CEOs coffee table book.

The book will have insights from top executives and industry leaders from the State, including Binod Kumar, CEO and Managing Director, Indian Bank; AR Unnikrishnan, Managing Director, Glass Group, Saint Gobain India; AD Padmasingh Issac, Founder and Chairman, Aachi Group of Companies; and LV Navaneeth, Chief Executive Officer, The Hindu Group.

The book was released as part of ‘CEO CONFLUENCE 3.0’, organised by the CII in the run up to its Tamil Nadu State Annual Meeting for 2025-26. It has been com-



(From left) LV Navaneeth, CEO, The Hindu Group; SKM Shree Shivkumar, MD, SKM Egg Products Export India Ltd; VG Sakthikumar, CMD, Schwing Stetter India Pvt Ltd; C Devarajan, MD, URC Construction Pvt Ltd; Santhanam, former Chairman, CII Southern Region; M Ponnuswami, CMD, Pon Pure Chemicals Group; NK Ranganath, past Chairman, CII TN State Council; Narayan Lakshman, Chairman, CII Tamil Nadu CEO Forum; Anand Roy, MD and CEO, Star Health and Allied Insurance Company Ltd; and AR Unnikrishnan, MD, Glass Group, Saint Gobain India Pvt Ltd

piled in collaboration with management consultancy company Kearney.

The conference also saw the presence of N Ram, Dir-

ector, The Hindu Publishing Group, who shared his thoughts on the unfolding geopolitical crisis and how India should navigate itself

in such a situation.

He said the Indian government had erred by weakening its relationship with Russia under pressure from the

US, especially with respect to the purchase of crude at discounted prices.

‘WRONG SIDE’

“The Indian establishment finds itself on the wrong side strategically, in my opinion. Had you maintained a more robust relationship with Russia and continued to insist on importing crude because you are getting it at a good price and refine it and export it to Europe... that was a good deal for India,” he said.

He added that India should have, like China, held firm and not made concessions that did not work to its strategic advantage. “A disturbing aspect of this is the failure to disclose facts that people are entitled to know. People are very confused about this... they face difficulties on the ground.”

What makes Shahed drones decisive in modern warfare

bl.explainer

Rohan Das
Chennai

With modern warfare having moved away from boots on the ground to beams in the sky, the US-Iran war has thrown the spotlight on a class of disruptive weapons helping Iran cause havoc in the GCC countries.

Shahed drones are unmanned aircraft systems often called ‘kamikaze drones’. Like the Japanese kamikaze planes in the Second World War, these drones are not intended to return after a mission but to fly into a target and detonate, destroying themselves in the process.

They carry with them built-in explosive payloads, which detonate with the drone and cause significant infrastructure damage to the targets.

What makes them particularly attractive is the fact that they are low cost and, hence, can be sent in swarms to overwhelm defence systems. Countries countering these drones will often have to expend expensive missiles in their arsenal to take them down.

Though they existed earlier, these drones first gained notoriety during the



interest in such drones.

He said that Zuppa has already got the airframes ready to build something of this category and is now in the process of demonstrating it to the armed forces.

“Our design is not similar to Shahed’s because in India you have to take into account the fact that a lot of our action happens in high-altitude areas, which means the aerodynamics have to be ideally optimised. This is not really the case with Shahed. We have designed our models keeping the high-altitude factor in mind,” he added.

Similarly, Odisha-based start-up IG Defence has announced that it is putting together an indigenous version of Shahed under its ‘Project KAL’.

However, it has to be noted that most of these projects are in the R&D phase and will take a while before they can be deployed on the battlefield.

Meanwhile, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky has said that teams of Ukrainian military experts have been sent to Qatar, the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia to help them defend against drones being launched from Iran, given the expertise the country has built up while countering Russian attacks.

HFCL bags \$1.1 b global deal for OFC supply

Our Bureau
Mumbai

HFCL Ltd announced a five-year deal with a global municipal corporation for the supply of high-quality, high-fibre-count optical fibre cables (OFC) at a potential value of around \$1.10 billion (₹10,159 crore) based on prevailing selling prices of OFC products being supplied.

“Minimum quantity of multi-million fibre kilometres of high-quality, high-fibre-count OFC to be supplied in each calendar year starting from CY26 to CY28, which shall automatically extend to CY29 and CY30,” said the company in a stock exchange filing.

High fibre count OFC are largely used in data centres.

Panasonic eyes 50% AC sales growth

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Panasonic India is targeting around 50 per cent growth in air-conditioner sales this year, even as the industry prepares for price increases of 12-15 per cent amid rising input costs and higher logistics expenses linked to the West Asia crisis.

Air-conditioner makers are preparing to raise prices due to higher costs of key raw materials, such as copper and aluminium, along with rising logistics costs linked to disruptions in global shipping routes. The expected price hikes also reflect revised energy-efficiency norms introduced by the Bureau of Energy Efficiency.

However, Panasonic plans to adopt a more calibrated pricing approach and will not



MARKET SHARE. Panasonic currently holds about 7-8% share in India's room air-conditioner market. [REUTERS](#)

pass on the full cost increase to consumers, said Abhishek Verma, Business Head and Product Chief-AC Group (RAC & CAC) at Panasonic Life Solutions India.

“We believe demand is just about to peak this summer,” Verma said, adding that industry demand could grow around 40 per cent over last year if the current trends continue.

Panasonic has recently in-

troduced 57 air-conditioner models, including units equipped with its dustbuster technology, which enables self-cleaning of the outdoor unit to improve cooling efficiency.

The company has been consolidating its presence in the premium segment, with about 45 per cent of its current AC sales coming from its smart air-conditioner range. At the same time,

Panasonic plans to extend advanced energy-saving technologies and connected features to mid and entry-level models.

1.1 MILLION UNITS

“The idea is to democratise energy-efficient and smart features that were earlier limited to premium products and bring them to mid and entry-level segments,” Verma said.

Panasonic currently holds about 7-8 per cent share in India's room air-conditioner market, trailing Voltas, which commands around 18-20 per cent, and LG Electronics with 17 per cent.

Verma said Panasonic is targeting around 1.1 million units in annual AC sales this year, as part of its roadmap to double manufacturing capacity to about 2 million units by FY28.

Mercedes, Audi plan price hikes from April

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Luxury carmakers Mercedes-Benz and Audi have announced price increases of up to 2 per cent across their model ranges from April 1, citing currency volatility and rising input costs, in the latest round of hikes in India's premium car market.

Mercedes-Benz India said it will implement a price correction of around 2 per cent across its portfolio, marking the German automaker's second price hike in 2026 after a similar increase in January.

“Starting April 1, we will be implementing a price correction of around 2 per cent across our portfolio. This decision is largely driven by continued forex volatility, particularly the sustained depreciation of the rupee against the euro, along with rising input costs,” Brendon Sissing, Vice-President, Sales and Marketing, Mercedes-Benz India, said.



RUPEE SLIDE. The fresh hikes come as luxury carmakers grapple with sharp currency movements, which have pushed up the cost of importing vehicles and components

Based on current prices, the revision could translate into increases ranging from ₹89,000 to ₹7.33 lakh, depending on the model.

Mercedes-Benz currently sells vehicles in India priced between ₹44.45 lakh for the A-Class sedan and ₹3.67 crore for the AMG G63.

AUDI PRICE INCREASE

German rival Audi India also announced a price increase of up to 2 per cent across its model range, effective April 1. “Due to rising input costs and currency fluctuations,

we are implementing a price adjustment of up to 2 per cent effective from April 1, 2026. We remain committed to minimising the impact of the price hike on our customers,” Balbir Singh Dhillon, Brand Director, Audi India, said.

Based on current pricing, the increase could translate into about ₹86,000 on the Audi Q3, the company's most affordable model priced from ₹43.23 lakh and up, and ₹4.64 lakh on the performance-focused RS Q8, which starts at ₹2.32 crore

(both ex-showroom). Audi's locally assembled models in India include the A4 and A6 sedans, and the Q3, Q3 Sportback, Q5 and Q7 SUVs, while the brand also sells imported models, such as the A5 Sportback, Q8, Q8 e-tron and e-tron GT.

The fresh hikes come as luxury carmakers grapple with sharp currency movements, which have pushed up the cost of importing vehicles and components.

India imports a significant portion of luxury cars or key components from Germany and the United Kingdom, making the segment particularly sensitive to exchange-rate fluctuations.

Compared to last year, the rupee has depreciated by over 6 per cent against the dollar; declines against the euro and British pound are in double digits, increasing cost pressures on manufacturers.

Several luxury carmakers had already raised prices earlier this year, with BMW and Mercedes-Benz implementing hikes from January.

Invesco Mutual Fund

Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd.

(CIN: U67190MH2005PTC153471), 2101-A, 21st Floor, A Wing, Marathon Futurax, N. M. Joshi Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai - 400 013

Telephone: +91 22 6731 0000, Email: mfservices@invescoindia.com; www.invescomutualfund.com

NOTICE-CUM-ADDENDUM

Addendum to the Statement of Additional Information of Invesco Mutual Fund

The investors / unitholders are requested to take note of following change to Statement of Additional Information (“SAI”) of Invesco Mutual Fund (“**the Fund**”), pursuant to change in the constitution of Board of Directors of Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd. (“IAM”).

Change in the constitution of the Board of Directors of Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd.:

Mr. Raj Narain Bhardwaj has resigned as an Independent Director from the Board of IAM with effect from close of business hours on **Thursday, March 12, 2026**. Accordingly, all references of Mr. Raj Narain Bhardwaj will be deleted from the SAI of the Fund.

All other terms & conditions of the SAI of the Fund will remain unchanged.

This addendum forms an integral part of the Statement of Additional Information of Invesco Mutual Fund as amended from time to time.

For Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd. (Investment Manager for Invesco Mutual Fund)

Sd/-

Saurabh Nanavati

Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer

Date: March 13, 2026

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

QUICKLY.

Crude oil heads for weekly gains



Singapore: Crude oil prices headed for weekly gains as of Friday, despite the US trying to ease supply concerns by issuing a 30-day license for countries to buy Russian oil. Brent futures for May rose \$1.02 to \$101.48 a barrel at 0730 GMT. US WTI crude for April was up 94 cents at \$96.67. REUTERS

Aluminium snaps 3-day gains as dollar firms

Aluminium fell snapping a three-day run of gains, as the dollar strengthened on fading prospects for more US rate cuts, although shipping disruption in the war-hit Middle East kept the metal on course for a weekly rise. Benchmark three-month aluminium on the LME was down 1.7 per cent at \$3,458 a tonne as of 1030 GMT. REUTERS

Palm oil posts weekly gain on higher crude oil prices



Jakarta: Malaysian palm oil futures logged a second consecutive week of gains as a surge in crude oil prices boosted demand for biodiesel feedstock. The benchmark palm oil contract for May delivery on the Bursa Malaysia Derivatives Exchange was up 23 ringgit at 4,564 ringgit (\$1,159.26) a tonne and rose 4.51 per cent for the week. REUTERS

Sugar industry urges govt to raise ethanol blending

SECTOR DEMAND. Deliberations begin with Food Minister to increase it above 20%, stressing ethanol’s role in energy security and farmer support

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Encouraged by a higher share of ethanol supplied against commitments compared with grain-based distilleries, the sugar industry has urged Food Minister Pralhad Joshi to consider raising ethanol blending beyond the current 20 per cent.

Government sources indicated that deliberations have begun on increasing ethanol usage, as significant production capacity remains under-utilised due to lower demand.

One option under consideration is raising the blending level above E20.

Joshi is learnt to have assured industry representatives that the government would take up the ethanol issue once the current pressures on LPG and crude oil

ease. On March 11, Indian Sugar & Bio-energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) President Niraj Shirgaokar and Director-General Deepak Ballani met Joshi and discussed challenges facing the sugar and bio-energy sector, the industry body said in a social media post.

BIOFUELS’ ROLE

“India’s heavy dependence on imported crude oil and LPG makes the country vulnerable to geopolitical disruptions and price volatility. Domestic biofuel production, particularly ethanol from sugarcane, must therefore be viewed not only as an agricultural or environmental initiative but as a strategic pillar of national energy security,” Ballani told *businessline*.

The ethanol blending programme has already helped cut crude import depend-



LION’S SHARE. Sources say that the sugar industry supplied 119 crore litres of ethanol — 41% of its committed quantity of 292 crore litres — during November-February of the current ethanol supply year

ence, save foreign exchange and provide a stable income stream to farmers, he said.

“A clear policy roadmap to scale up ethanol usage will

help cushion the country against global fuel shocks while strengthening rural economies and accelerating the transition to cleaner en-

ergy,” Ballani added. The meeting also discussed the evolving geopolitical situation in global energy markets, the need to accelerate

ethanol blending in India, expansion of blending infrastructure and the roadmap beyond E20, ISMA said earlier.

SUPPLY PROGRESS

According to industry sources, the sugar industry supplied 119 crore litres of ethanol — 41 per cent of its committed quantity of 292 crore litres — during November-February of the current ethanol supply year (ESY). This included 94 crore litres from sugarcane juice, 21 crore litres from B-heavy molasses and 4 crore litres from C-heavy molasses supplied to oil marketing companies (OMCs).

In comparison, grain-based distilleries supplied 209 crore litres — 27 per cent of their committed 766 crore litres.

This comprised 123 crore litres from maize, 69 crore

litres from FCI rice and 17 crore litres from 100 per cent broken rice.

RURAL ECONOMY

ISMA said on Friday that the ethanol blending programme (EBP) is emerging as a transformative initiative that reduces reliance on imported fossil fuels while creating new opportunities for the sugar, bio-energy and agricultural sectors. Expanding ethanol blending and building a robust bioenergy ecosystem can play a strategic role in cutting fossil fuel imports while strengthening the rural economy, it said.

“Ethanol supply has increased from 38 crore litres in 2014 to over 660 crore litres, generating ₹1.18 lakh crore in payments to farmers and saving about ₹1.36 lakh crore in foreign exchange through reduced crude imports,” the association said.

Gold loses sheen as \$ gains strength

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Gold prices fell by ₹1,904 on Friday to ₹158,399 per 10 g against ₹160,303 on Thursday due to a weak trend in the global markets.

The yellow metal’s prices have retreated for a second consecutive week, shedding nearly 1.5 per cent in the international markets to trade below \$5,100 an ounce level as the dollar index jumped above 100 points.

The dollar index surged against six major foreign currencies, including the Euro, the Japanese Yen, the British Pound, the Canadian Dollar, the Swedish Krona and the Swiss Franc.

Amid the growing global turmoil and the raging war in West Asia pushing up crude

oil prices, investors are increasingly betting on green-back than gold.

Similarly, silver was down at ₹260,488 per kg against ₹268,301, according to the Indian Bullion and Jewellers Association of India.

On the MCX, gold for April delivery was down by ₹116 to ₹160,155 per 10 g, while the June contract dipped by ₹286 to ₹164,501 on Friday.

SOARING CRUDE OIL

Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst-Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said gold traded weak on the fear of rising crude oil prices pushing up inflation projections. A higher inflation could delay interest rate cuts by the Federal Reserve, which is limiting the bullish momentum in bullion.

With the Fed’s policy meeting scheduled next week, market participants are likely to stay cautious as the central bank’s stance on inflation and rate cuts will be a key trigger for gold, he said.

Aamir Makda, Commodity & Currency Analyst, Choice Broking, said the primary catalysts for this decline in gold prices was a strengthening dollar, bolstered by rising oil prices and geopolitical concerns in West Asia.

BEARISH OUTLOOK

This apart, US Treasury yields surged to 4.27 per cent, exerting significant pressure on the metal, he added. The near-term outlook in India remains moderately bearish and traders are encouraged to utilise a sell-on-rise strategy for upcoming sessions, he said.

‘Tech adoption, improved seed varieties boost domestic wheat and rice output’

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Wheat and rice output have risen over the past five years, aided by the adoption of production and protection technologies to address biotic and abiotic stresses, including high-yielding climate-resilient varieties and cost-effective pre- and post-harvest practices, according to Bhagirath Choudhary, Union Minister of State for Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare.

In a written reply in the Rajya Sabha on Friday, he said wheat production was estimated at 117.95 million tonnes (mt) in 2024-25, up

4.65 mt from 113.29 mt in the previous year and 109.59 mt in 2020-21.

Rice production was estimated at 150.18 mt in 2024-25, 12.36 mt higher than 137.83 mt in the previous year. Output stood at 124.37 mt in 2020-21.

As of February 16, stocks in the central pool stood at 24.83 mt of wheat and 35.26 mt of rice, well above the stocking norms of 13.8 mt and 7.61 mt respectively.

“The rise in wheat and rice production in 2024-25 is due to both expanded acreage and improved productivity in recent years, along with the adoption of production and protection technologies to tackle biotic and



abiotic stresses,” he said.

IRAN IMPACT

Replying to a question on the impact of Iran-related uncertainties on basmati exports, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said that exports to Iran had grown 11.57 per cent in value (rupee terms) and 26.1 per

cent in volume up to January 2026, indicating steady trade.

However, following the outbreak of conflict in West Asia on February 28, stakeholders, including basmati exporters, had reported disruptions in maritime and air cargo routes, higher freight costs due to re-routing and war-risk surcharges, cargo pile-ups at ports and logistics hubs, and financial stress from the longer transit cycles.

He said the government is closely monitoring the geopolitical developments in West Asia and the Gulf, and had taken steps to mitigate the disruption to exports and to protect livelihoods.

Cotton likely to remain mainstream fibre: ICAC

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Cotton will continue to remain a mainstream fibre as many applications still prefer the natural fibre for its comfort, breathability and natural characteristics, despite its share in the global fibre consumption declining.

According to the International Cotton Advisory Council (ICAC) World Textile Demand report, cotton’s market share in global fibre consumption has dropped to below 25 per cent in recent years from nearly 40 per cent in the early 2000s.

The US Department of Agriculture said: “This limits the potential growth for cotton product imports despite record consumer demand for apparel and home textiles. Competition with MMF (man-made fibre) products is especially challenging with respect to Chinese MMF product ex-

ports.” According to Prabhu Damodharan, Convenor, Indian Texpreneurs Federation (ITF), cotton’s decline in global fibre share has been gradual and structural, mainly driven by two factors.

TWO FACTORS FOR DIP

The first is the cost dynamics favouring synthetic fibres such as polyester. The second is significant improvement in the functionality of alternate fibres, particularly polyester and cellulosic fibres such as viscose, he said.

Ramnuj Das Boob, Vice-President of All India Cotton Brokers Association and a sourcing agent in Raichur, said the issue is not necessarily declining cotton demand, but faster growth of competing fibres. The modern textiles sector is increasingly using blended fabrics such as cotton plus polyester, cotton plus elastane, cotton plus viscose, lycra and recycled yarn, he said.



SHRINKING SHARE. Cotton’s market share in global fibre consumption has dropped to below 25% in recent years from nearly 40% in the early 2000s

COMPETING WITH MMF

The USDA said competition with MMF products is especially challenging with respect to Chinese MMF product exports.

Dhamodaran said: “While these factors have reduced cotton’s share in the overall fibre basket, cotton will continue to remain a mainstream fibre because many applications still prefer it for

its comfort, breathability and natural characteristics.”

Das Boob said cotton will remain indispensable in apparel and home textiles.

“Demand will not collapse, but growth will be slower than that of synthetic fibres,” he said.

Though the share of cotton is falling, demand has been stable, said the All India Cotton Brokers Association

Vice-President. “The pie is growing, but cotton’s slice is shrinking. Blended yarns are increasing globally. Spinners are increasingly producing poly-cotton yarns,” he said.

INDIAN PERSPECTIVE

The future of cotton lies in quality, sustainability and productivity improvements, said Das Boob.

The ITF Convenor said from India’s perspective, improving yield per hectare in cotton is critical. “Higher productivity can enhance farmer incomes, and at the same time ensure that cotton prices remain reasonable, helping cotton retain its competitiveness with other fibres,” he said.

Anand Popat, a Rajkot-based cotton, yarn and cotton waste trader, said speculators had pushed cotton prices higher during the period, leading to a drop in the natural fibre’s market share.

CAI cuts cotton import estimate

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

A firm trend in global prices, coupled with a weakening rupee and rising freight costs triggered by the West Asia war has prompted trade body Cotton Association of India (CAI) to reduce its import projections by around 3 lakh bales for 2025-26 ending in September to 47 lakh bales.

The CAI expects imports to be around 47 lakh bales during the 2025-26 season, compared with its earlier projection of 50 lakh bales.

“We have reduced the import projections because the international prices have moved up and the rupee has depreciated. So the imports will become costlier. Also, Indian cotton prices are relatively stabilised now. As a result, compared to the replacement cost of imports, the Indian prices are lower or equal,” said Vinay N Kotak,

President, Cotton Association of India (CAI). Besides the rise in freight rates, the transit time has also increased due to the war.

EXPORT PROSPECTS

The CAI’s import estimates are higher by 6 lakh bales at 47 lakh bales over last year’s 41 lakh bales. By the end of February, about 36 lakh bales of cotton are estimated to have arrived in the country, as mills and trade took advantage of the duty-free regime until the end of December and imported substantial quantities.

Kotak said prospects for the export of cotton are likely to improve in the days ahead. “If the rupee depreciates and if the international prices move up further following the crude prices, there could be some exports taking place from India,” Kotak said. “Due to the locational advantage, exports can take place for countries like Bangladesh and China.

For their immediate requirement, these countries may be forced to turn to India for exports,” he added.

The CAI has maintained the cotton export estimate at 15 lakh bales for the 2025-26 season; by the end of February, about 7 lakh bales were exported.

The CAI also raised the crop projections marginally by 3.5 lakh bales to 320.5 lakh bales (of 170 kg each) on higher than projected output in Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh, among others. Kotak said the yields were better in Maharashtra, especially around the Vidarbha region and also in Karnataka and Telangana this year.

Further, the CAI also revised upward the consumption estimates by 10 lakh bales to 315 lakh bales for 2025-26. Till February 2026, the consumption was estimated at 131.25 lakh bales. The CAI estimates the closing stock at the end of the 2025-26 season at 98.09 lakh bales.

Panel moots green ammonia push as urea imports near record high

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Chemicals and Fertilizers has urged the government to formulate a “comprehensive roadmap for the phased adoption of green ammonia in urea, DAP, and NPK production”.

The panel has called for a strategy encompassing plant-wise targets, investment plans, technology partnerships, infrastructure development and the requisite quantum of subsidy support. This comes at a time when urea imports are set to hit a record high in 2025-26. Additionally, the panel recommended the establishment of a ‘Fertilizer Supply Security Fund.’

India has already imported 98 lakh tonnes (lt) of



urea during the first 11 months of the current fiscal year. Industry estimates suggest another 3-5 lt will arrive by March 31, while the government expects total arrivals of approximately 17 lt by May 31. This surge is poised to eclipse the previous record of 98.28 lt set in 2020-21.

GOOD OPPORTUNITY

In its Demands for Grants report tabled on Friday, the

committee noted that the National Green Hydrogen Mission, with an outlay of ₹19,744 crore through 2029-30, presents a significant opportunity to reduce the fertilizer sector’s reliance on imported natural gas.

India currently consumes 170-190 lt of ammonia annually, largely derived from natural gas.

This leaves the sector vulnerable to global price volatility and triggers sharp spikes in subsidy expenditure during international price shocks.

The committee, chaired by TMC Rajya Sabha MP Kirti Azad, advised the Department of Fertilizers and the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy to collaborate on this strategy to mitigate LNG import exposure and support India’s climate and self-reliance goals.

CIS buying boosts orthodox tea prices in Kochi auctions

V Sajeev Kumar
Kochi

Active buying by CIS and neighbouring countries pushed up the prices of orthodox leaf teas at the Kochi auctions, with the average price realisation rising by ₹2 per kg.

There was strong demand from Russia and other CIS countries in Sale 11 for good quality teas.

RISING TRANSIT TIME

However, the demand from West Asian buyers remained subdued amid the current geopolitical tensions in the region. Rising freight costs are also prompting buyers to defer additional purchases, traders said.

Anil George, President of the Tea Trade Association of Cochin, said export enquiries in the auctions had

dropped as geopolitical tensions in West Asia are disrupting shipping routes, forcing shipments to take longer routes such as the Cape of Good Hope, increasing transit time and costs.

The auctioneers Forbes, Ewart & Figgis said the orthodox leaf market was strong, with 97 per cent sales out of the offered quantity of 1,49,148 kg.

High-priced whole leaf was lower, while the rest was firm to dearer. Medium broken were firm to dearer, especially tippy grades.

The demand was strong in CTC leaf, with medium broken and fannings firm to dearer. The quantity offered was 27,500 kg, with a sales percentage of 92.

In CTC dust, good liquoring teas were lower by ₹2-₹3 per kg. The offered quantity was 6,13,909 kg with a sales percentage of 90.

Expecting a rebound, SOPA hikes soymeal exports projections for 2025-26 oil year

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

Soymeal producers are seeing a rebound in demand in both domestic and export markets and have revised projections for the 2025-26 oil year (starting October).

The Soyabean Processors Association of India (SOPA) has raised its export estimate by 2 lakh tonnes (lt) to 10 lt from the earlier projection of 8 lt. “Based on the export trend, we have revised soymeal export projections for 2025-26 to 10 lt and increased soyabean crushing estimates to 102 lt (97 lt). Domestic feed consumption has also been revised up to 62 lt from 60 lt,” said DN Pathak, Executive Director, SOPA.

However, exports during October-February are lower



at 7.12 lt compared with 9.50 lt in the same period last year. Soymeal production has also declined to 37.48 lt (40.64 lt).

Domestic consumption by the livestock feed and food sectors is down at 26.50 lt (27.50 lt) and 3.45 lt (3.65 lt), respectively.

ARRIVALS DOWN

Lower soyabean arrivals have weighed on crushing volumes. Arrivals till Febru-

ary stood at 57 lt (66 lt), and crushing was down to 47.50 lt (51.50 lt).

SOPA pegs the current soybean stocks at 58.41 lt, including 7 lt procured under the price support scheme.

France (1.11 lt), Nepal (85,665 tonnes), Bangladesh (65,949 tonnes), Germany (65,262 tonnes) and Kenya (53,084 tonnes) were the top buyers of Indian soymeal in the October-February period.

QUICKLY.

Sigma divests stake in
Extrovis for \$15 million

Hyderabad: Sigma Advanced Systems Ltd, an integrated aerospace and defence company, has completed the divestment of its entire 36.52 per cent stake in Extrovis AG, a Swiss-based pharma company, for \$15 million (₹137.61 crore). “This deal gives the company additional financial resources for the expansion of its aerospace and defence business,” a company executive said. **OUR BUREAU**

Heritage Foods inaugurates
24 m litre ice cream factory

Hyderabad: Heritage Foods has inaugurated an ice cream manufacturing facility at Shamirpet, near here, as part of its strategy to strengthen its value-added dairy portfolio. The plant has an installed production capacity of approximately 24 million litres per annum, with potential to enable the company to scale up ice cream operations five times over 7-8 years. **OUR BUREAU**

Govt introduces amendment Bill to enforce protection of transgenders

TOUGH MEASURES. To uphold constitutional guarantee of bodily integrity and protect against trafficking

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The Union government on Friday moved to significantly tighten the legal framework governing the rights of transgender persons by introducing a Bill to amend the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019, in the Lok Sabha. The proposed legislation seeks to prescribe rigorous life imprisonment and a minimum fine of ₹5 lakh for the forced conversion of children to a transgender identity through mutilation, emasculation, castration or any surgical and hormonal procedures. In cases involving adults, such coercive acts will be punishable with imprisonment for up to 10 years, which may extend to life, alongside a fine of ₹2 lakh.



CRACKDOWN. The proposed legislation seeks to prescribe rigorous life imprisonment and a minimum fine of ₹5 lakh for the forced exploitation of children

The government’s statement of objects and reasons emphasises that these provisions will operate cumulatively with general criminal law to uphold the constitutional guarantee of bodily integrity and provide a legislative shield against

human trafficking and forced labour.

CHILD EXPLOITATION Beyond these punitive measures, the Bill proposes a significant widening of the legal definition of a transgender person.

The updated definition now encompasses socio-cultural identities such as *kiner*, *hijra*, *aravani* and *jogta*, as well as individuals with congenital variations in sex characteristics, including chromosomal patterns and endogenous hormone production. Crucially, a new provision has been brought in for action against anyone who forces, threatens or induces a non transgender child to dress, present or conduct themselves outwardly as a transgender person and who employs, uses or causes such a child to engage in begging, solicitation, servitude, forced or bonded labour. Such an act “shall be punishable with rigorous imprisonment for a term which shall not be less than 10 years but which may extend to 14 years, and shall

also be liable to fine, which shall not be less than ₹3 lakh,” the Bill said. To streamline the administrative and social transition of the community, the Bill introduces provisions for a designated authority to facilitate consequential changes in official documents. It also seeks to restructure the National Council by ensuring that regional representatives from the North, South, East, West, and the North-East, not below the rank of Director, are included in the body by rotation. Further, the legislation empowers relevant authorities to seek expert advice where necessary, ensuring that the legal and medical complexities of intersex variations and gender identity are addressed with professional precision.

Gas crunch: Industries in Gujarat allowed to use alternative fuels



SUPPLY SQUEEZE. The disruption of LNG imports through the Strait of Hormuz has forced Gujarat’s major suppliers to slash industrial gas deliveries by up to 50 per cent **BLOOMBERG**

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Amid tightening natural gas availability, Gujarat has permitted industries dependent on gas-based utilities to switch to alternative fuels without obtaining fresh environmental approvals. The temporary relaxation by the Gujarat Pollution Control Board is intended to help units maintain production while fuel supplies remain constrained.

FUEL SWITCH In a recent notification, the GPCB said industries could use approved liquid fuels to run boilers, furnaces and other utilities affected by gas shortages. Units must inform the board about the name of the utility, its capacity, the alternative fuel proposed and the quantity to be used. The regulator clarified that the use of alternate fuels must be proportionate to the shortfall in gas supply. “In the interest of the environment, non-approved fuels should not be used in any manner,” GPCB stated in the notification. The GPCB said the relaxation will remain valid for three months, after which the board will review the situation based on the availability of gas and decide

whether the temporary measure needs to be extended. Hailing the move, Pathik Patwari, Chair of the Gujarat Council of the Indian Chamber of Commerce said, “The notification from GPCB giving a blanket nod to industries to use alternative fuels is a welcome relief. However, the prices of some of these alternative fuels have started increasing, so the question on availability and affordability remains.” Under the board’s fuel notification, approved fuels include coal, lignite, furnace oil, light diesel oil (LDO), kerosene, naphtha, biogas, briquettes and charcoal, among others. Petroleum coke (petcoke) is also notified as an approved fuel but its use is restricted to specific sectors, such as cement manufacturing units, thermal power plants, glass and refractories industries, and only when the sulphur content is below seven per cent. The move from the GPCB comes at a time when India is currently facing a significant shortfall in natural gas and related commercial LPG supplies, largely due to disruptions in global energy flows triggered by ongoing geopolitical tensions in West Asia, especially the conflict involving the US, Israel and Iran.

Kandla port readies to handle 22 vessels over next 72 hours; surpasses 150 mt cargo throughput in FY26

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad



CARGO SURGE. This comes on the back of robust growth in the liquid and dry bulk segments, continuing the port’s strong performance trajectory after it crossed 150.16 mt in FY25

Even as Deendayal Port at Kandla surpassed last year’s cargo throughput of 150 million tonnes, over 18 days ahead of the year-end, the port Authority announced on social media that it is readying to handle over a couple of dozen vessels in the next 72 hours. DPA, which has not been disclosing detailed cargo movements since the US-Iran war erupted, took to X on Friday to announce that it is gearing up to “handle 22 vessels in the next 72 hours”. When contacted, officials

refused to divulge details regarding the origins or nature of the cargo, citing operational security and sensitive maritime conditions. The

post on X gains significance in the backdrop of reports that India is in talks with Iran to enable the safe passage of tankers bound for ports here.

Kandla’s location on the West Coast places it strategically close to the Strait of Hormuz, the world’s most critical oil-and-gas choke point through which nearly one-fifth of global crude flows, and which has been at the centre of tensions since the US-Iran conflict erupted, making disruptions there a direct concern for Gujarat’s energy-import hubs.

CARGO HANDLING Deendayal Port has handled over 150 mt of cargo in the current fiscal year, surpassing the landmark figure roughly 18 days before the financial year end on March 31.

Lila Global’s VLCC is first India-flagged vessel structured via GIFT City, starts maiden voyage

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad



MEGA TANKER. *Lila Jammagar* has a capacity of about 2,98,997 DWT, placing it among the largest crude carriers

Maritime platform Lila Global has acquired a very large crude carrier (VLCC), *Lila Jammagar*, marking the first time a vessel of this type has been structured through the International Financial Services Centre at Gujarat International Finance Tec-City and registered under the Indian flag. The tanker has been registered under RFL Shipping IFSC Pvt Ltd at GIFT City. The structure reflects a model in which vessels are owned through entities based in the IFSC, providing access to tax incentives, global capital and a regulatory framework tailored to maritime leasing. The vessel commenced its maiden voyage under the Indian flag, sailing from the Far East towards its loading port. *Lila Jammagar* has a ca-

capacity of about 298,997 deadweight tonnes (DWT), placing it among the world’s largest crude carriers typically deployed on long-haul routes transporting crude oil between major energy-producing and consuming regions. “This vessel reflects our commitment to strengthening long-term India-linked shipping capabilities, especially in the current geopolitical environment where

timely energy transportation is vital,” said Anil Sharma, Founder and CEO of Lila Global. He added that investing in Indian-flagged assets represents both an opportunity and a responsibility as India’s energy demand and trade volumes continue to expand. **CHARTERING BIZ** The addition of the VLCC is expected to deepen the group’s engagement with In-

dia’s PSU chartering market, where large tankers are typically deployed to transport crude oil for domestic refiners. Industry participants note that scale, operational reliability and strong compliance standards are key requirements in this segment. Beyond the individual transaction, the deal also underscores the gradual emergence of GIFT City as a hub for ship leasing and maritime finance. India has been seeking to replicate global maritime financing centres such as Singapore and Dubai by encouraging vessel ownership and leasing structures to be domiciled within its own financial ecosystem. The ecosystem has been expanding steadily. As of December 2025, the IFSC hosted 29 ship lessors that had collectively leased 34 vessels, with about \$71.1 million in financing extended by banking units operating in the centre.

Tata Motors bags orders for over 5,000 buses from State transport undertakings

Our Bureau
Mumbai



Tata Motors has secured cumulative orders for more than 5,000 buses and bus chassis from multiple State transport undertakings (STUs), reinforcing its position as a key supplier of mass mobility solutions. The orders were awarded through a competitive e-bidding process under the government procurement system and will be executed in phases in coordination with the respective STUs. The orders include those from the Maharashtra State Road Transport Corporation (MSRTC), the Gujarat State Road Transport Corporation (GSRTC), the North Western Karnataka Road Transport Corporation (NWKRTC), the Telangana State Road Transport Corporation (TGSRTC), the Bi-

BID PROCESS. The orders were awarded via a competitive e-bidding process under the government procurement system

har State Road Transport Corporation (BSRTC), the Rajasthan State Road Transport Corporation (RSRTC), the Kerala State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC), the Haryana Roadways and the Chandigarh Transport Undertaking (CTU).

“These orders reflect the trust that STUs place in Tata Motors’ mobility solutions,” said Anand S, Vice-President and Head, Commercial Passenger Vehicle Business, at Tata Motors. The orders span a range of models, including the Tata

Magna, Tata Cityride, Tata Starbus, Tata Starbus Prime and bus chassis platforms, such as the LPO 1618, LPO 1622 and LPO 1822. These vehicles are configured for intercity, long-haul and intra-city operations. **LIFECYCLE SUPPORT** Tata Motors has long been a major supplier to STUs and private fleet operators across India. Its commercial passenger vehicle portfolio ranges from 9-seater vans to 55-seater buses across multiple powertrain options. The company supports these vehicles through its Sampoorna Seva 2.0 lifecycle management programme, which provides maintenance support, assured turnaround times, genuine spare parts availability and breakdown assistance. Tata Motors also has a nationwide network of more than 4,500 sales and service touchpoints.

TN CM opens ₹13,000 crore Udangudi thermal plant unit 1

Our Bureau
Chennai



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin virtually inaugurated the thermal power plant

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin on Friday virtually inaugurated power generation from unit-1 of the 2 x 660 MW supercritical thermal power plant established at Udangudi in Thoothukudi district at a cost of ₹13,077 crore. The newly established supercritical thermal power plant has been set up by the Tamil Nadu Power Generation Corporation Ltd. The electricity generated from this plant will be connected to the grid and distributed through a 400 kV gas-insulated substation, said a release. **CAPACITY BOOST** Through this project, the State’s power generation

capacity will further increase, helping meet Tamil Nadu’s electricity demand and reducing the need to procure power from external markets. This will improve the financial position of the Electricity Board and significantly contribute to the socio-economic development of the State, the release said.

Health Min okays perpetual validity for FSSAI licences as part of regulatory reforms

Our Bureau
New Delhi



The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare has approved the proposal for perpetual validity of registrations and licences obtained by businesses from the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) to promote ease of doing business. This is among a series of regulatory and procedural reforms approved by the Ministry following deliberations with stakeholders and are aligned with the recommendations of the High-Level Committee on Non-Financial Regulatory Reforms constituted by the NITI Aayog. Earlier, registrations and licences had to be renewed periodically. “This reform will substantially reduce compliance costs, paperwork and the need for repeated interaction with licensing authorities for food

business operators (FBOs), while improving continuity of operations. It will enable regulatory resources to focus more effectively on enforcement, monitoring and capacity-building activities,” an official statement said.

THRESHOLD ENHANCED Meanwhile, effective April 1, the turnover threshold for registration will be increased from ₹12 lakh to ₹1.5 crore, and for State licensing up to ₹50 crore, with Central licensing applicable beyond this limit. “This rationalisation is intended to empower and strengthen the role of State au-

thorities by enabling them to focus more effectively on oversight, facilitation and enforcement of food safety regulations within their jurisdictions,” the statement added. This will lead to simpler compliance requirements, reduced paperwork and fees, elimination of pre-inspection and instant registration for food business operators.

DUAL COMPLIANCE In a bid to address dual compliance requirements, street food vendors registered with municipal corporations or town vending committees under the Street Vendors’ (Protection of Livelihood and Regulation of Street Vending) Act, 2014, will be considered as deemed registered under FSSAI, the statement added. This measure will benefit more than 10 lakh street food vendors by eliminating the requirement for multiple registrations across departments.

CBI questions Anil Ambani’s son Jai Anmol in probe into alleged ₹228 cr bank fraud case

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Friday questioned Jai Anmol Ambani, son of industrialist Anil Ambani, in connection with an alleged ₹228 crore bank fraud case involving Reliance Home Fin-

ance Ltd. According to officials, Jai Anmol appeared before the investigating officer at the CBI headquarters in New Delhi and was examined for about six-and-a-half hours. Investigators have asked him to appear again on Saturday for further questioning. The agency had registered an

FIR on December 12, 2025, naming Reliance Home, its promoters and directors, including Jai Anmol, along with former company executive Ravindra Sudhakar, as well as unknown persons and unidentified public servants. The case was filed on the basis of a complaint by Union Bank of India

CANTONMENT BOARD
St. Thomas Mount cum Pallavaram
REVENUE DEPARTMENT
PUBLIC NOTICE

It is informed to all the General Public and Property Owners/Tenants/Lessees inside the Cantonment limits of St. Thomas Mount and Pallavaram that: Cantonment Board St. Thomas Mount cum Pallavaram (CBMP) proposes to carry out the Triennial Revision of Assessment for the Period 2025-2028 for the properties inside the Cantonment limits.

In this connection, it has been decided by the CBMP to revise the Property Tax for the properties within the Cantonment limits for residential purposes at the rate of 3.5% on the existing Annual Rateable Value (ARV) and for Commercial, at the rate of 7.0% on the existing ARV w.e.f. 01.04.2025.

Hence, any objection on the above fixed rates by the Property Owners/Tenants/Lessees shall be submitted to the CBMP Office at North Parade Road, St. Thomas Mount, within **ONE Month** from the date of Publication of this notice, failing which no objections will be heard after the notice period.

Dr. Vinod Vikneswaran .A, IDES
Chief Executive Officer, Cantonment Board
No.STM/REV/TroPT/25-28/0529

QUICKLY.

Apple cuts China App Store commission fees



Beijing: Apple said on Thursday it would lower the commission fees collected by the company from its App Store in mainland China in a huge win for Chinese developers following apparent pressure from regulators in the US tech giant's second-largest market. Fees for in-app purchases and paid transactions will be lowered to 25 per cent from 30 per cent starting on Sunday, the company said. In-app purchase transactions for developers belonging to Apple's small business and mini apps partner programmes will be cut to 12 per cent from 15 per cent.

Bitcoin slips as oil surges above \$100 on Iran war

Bitcoin fluctuated close to recent price levels as oil briefly jumped back above \$100 a barrel on deepening concerns about the Iran conflict. The cryptocurrency fell as much as 2 per cent following attacks on two oil tankers in Iraqi waters, before settling in at around \$70,000. Brent crude soared as much as 10.5 per cent, prompting risk-off sentiment across markets, including equities.

ED freezes 90 accounts in money laundering case

New Delhi: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Friday said it has frozen 90 bank accounts and incriminating material in the form of digital as well as documentary evidence during searches carried out on March 12 at 19 premises across Chandigarh, Haryana, Punjab and Bengaluru. The action was in connection with the IDFC First Bank Scam involving embezzlement of public funds amounting to ₹597 crore pertaining to the Haryana government, Chandigarh Municipal Corporation and other government accounts.

Accenture names new leadership team for Reinvention Services

Our Bureau

Bengaluru

Accenture has announced its new leadership team for Reinvention Services, which is led by Manish Sharma, Accenture's Chief Strategy and Services Officer.

These leaders are part of the company's implementation of a new design for Reinvention Services that will enable Accenture to create leading solutions faster and embed data and AI more easily into its solutions and delivery. These changes are effective March 31, 2026.

Accenture is organising its services around how its clients operate and will bring its clients end-to-end solutions, including with its ecosystem, through seven units called Reinvention Partners, which are responsible for helping clients reinvent.

The Reinvention Partners and their leaders include Cybersecurity, led by Harpreet Sidhu; Digital Core, led by Ajoy Menon; Finance, led by Arundhati Chakraborty; Industry and Enterprise, led by Muqsit Ashraf; Song, led by Nididi Oteh; Supply Chain and Engineering, led by Tracey Countryman; and Talent, led by Karalee Close.

REINVENTION ENGINES

The new design also includes three Reinvention Engines, which are how Accenture will develop stronger, more specialised skills; the most AI-enabled ways of delivering its services; cutting-edge innovation; and the most advanced tools and methods.

While the Reinvention Partners are where Accenture helps its clients reinvent, the Reinvention Engines are where Accenture reinvents itself. AI and Data

Sportstar Aces Awards celebrate athletes powering Indian sports

FELICITATION. Women's cricket pioneers honoured; outstanding athletes recognised for their contributions

The Hindu Sports Bureau

Mumbai

The eighth edition of the Sportstar Aces Awards was held at the Taj Mahal Palace in Mumbai on Friday, celebrating the athletes, teams and moments that shaped the past year in Indian sport.

If the evening had a defining thread, it was the story of women's cricket in India and the generations that carried it forward.

Ten former captains of the national side were honoured on stage, among them Jhulan Goswami, Diana Edulji, Neetu David and Shubhangi Kulkarni, alongside Sudha Shah, Nilima Jogekar, Sandhya Agarwal, Purnima Rau, Pramila Bhat and Chandrakanta Kaul.

Their felicitation came at a moment when the women's game in India has reached unprecedented heights.

The national team captured its maiden ODI World Cup title last November, while India soon added another landmark by winning the inaugural Blind Women's T20 World Cup.



TOP HONOURS. Nari Contractor receives the Lifetime Achievement (Male) award from Sunil Gavaskar and Jayen Mehta, MD, Amul, at the Sportstar Aces Awards 2026 in Mumbai on Friday while Diana Edulji greets Lifetime Achievement (Female) winner MD Valsamma (right) EMMANUEL YOGINI



other landmark by winning the inaugural Blind Women's T20 World Cup.

TRIBUTE TO PIONEERS

Reflecting on the journey of women's sport in India, Nirmala Lakshman, Chairperson of The Hindu Group, paid tribute to the pioneers who laid the foundation for the present generation.

"Long before the spotlight arrived, pioneers like PT Usha, Karnam Malleswari, Diana Edulji and Shanta Rangaswamy carried the dreams

of Indian women's sport on their shoulders," she said. "They competed for India in an era with limited infrastructure, little recognition and almost no financial support. Yet they persevered — driven purely by passion and pride."

She added that their courage created the pathway for the progress visible today, noting that *Sportstar*, too, has sought to honour that spirit through its work.

"For 48 years, *Sportstar* has carried forward that leg-

acy in the world of sport — celebrating not just victories, but the spirit, sacrifice and perseverance that define great athletes."

SKILL AND RESILIENCE

Two stalwarts of Indian sport were recognised with Lifetime Achievement honours during the evening. Former India Test captain Nari Contractor was celebrated for a career marked by skill, leadership and resilience, while pioneering hurdler MD Valsamma was hon-



STRATEGIC SHIFT. Air India has activated contingency flight paths to Europe and the US

popularity with tourists is among the factors being considered for the move.

They added that the country is expected to see a further rise in tourist inflows during the upcoming summer season.

As such, Air India is evaluating deployment of a Boeing 787 on the Osaka route.

Besides, Indonesia and Cambodia are countries of active expansion interest for Air India, sources added.

When contacted, Air India did not elicit a response.

Notably, the evaluation of East Asia routes comes amid disruptions in West Asian airspace.

The escalation of the con-

flict involving the United States, Israel and Iran has resulted in the closure of select Gulf airspace, leading to widespread cancellations by India-based carriers to West Asia and Europe.

Industry data indicated a significant number of flight cancellations operated by Indian carriers following the airspace closures.

AIRSPACE DISRUPTIONS

However, industry insiders said the airline has activated contingency routing plans that were developed during last year's regional airspace disruptions in West Asia to sustain connectivity to key markets including the United Kingdom, Europe, Canada and the US.

Speaking to *businessline*, a senior airline official had earlier said the network planning team had "war-gamed multiple conflict scenarios" and identified viable alternatives in the event of restricted Gulf airspace.

Accordingly, services bound for Europe, the US and Canada are being routed through airspace over the Red Sea, Egypt and the Mediterranean Sea to bypass constrained zones. These adjustments add approximately 30-45 minutes to average European flight durations.

In addition, for services to the US and Canada, Air India has incorporated technical halts at Rome and Vienna for refuelling before continuing transatlantic operations.

Adobe CEO Narayen to step down after 18 years

Our Bureau

Bengaluru



Shantanu Narayen, CEO of Adobe

Shantanu Narayen will step down as Chief Executive of Adobe after nearly two decades in the role, the company said on Tuesday, adding that he will remain chair of the board until a successor is appointed.

Narayen joined Adobe in 1998 as Vice-President and General Manager of its Engineering Technology Group. He was appointed President and Chief Operating Officer in 2005 and became Chief Executive Officer in 2007. During his tenure as CEO, the company recorded its highest levels of revenue.

DIGITAL ECONOMY

When he became CEO, Adobe was known for selling boxed copies of Photoshop in retail stores. Now, the software giant dominates several corners of the digital economy, including creative design, marketing analytics and document management.

In an email to employees, he wrote, "What attracted me to Adobe 28 years ago was our leadership in creating new market categories, world-class products, a relentless desire to innovate in every functional area of the company, and the people I met during the interview process. We have continued to create new markets, deliver world-class products, drive innovation in everything we do, and attract and retain the best and brightest employees."

Narayen also pointed to the next phase of creativity being shaped by AI, new workflows and entirely new forms of expression, saying the company has consistently anticipated and led such shifts. He added his confidence in the future rests not only on Adobe's technology but also on its people and their ingenuity, resilience and commitment to customers.

Narayen belongs to the Class of 1980 at the prestigious Hyderabad Public School.

Born and brought up in

Hyderabad, Narayen maintained a deep relationship with the city even after moving to the US for higher studies, completing his bachelor's in engineering at Osmania University.

He did his master's degree in computer science from Bowling Green State University and holds an MBA from the Haas School of Business, University of California, Berkeley.

Narayen began his career in 1986 in Silicon Valley at a start-up called Measurex Automation Systems. Before joining Adobe, Narayen held product development roles at Apple and Silicon Graphics, and also co-founded an early photo-sharing startup, Pictra.

GROWTH STRATEGY

He recently joined the school's other celebrity CXOs, such as Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella, World Bank Group Chairman Ajay Banga and Fairfax Financial Holdings Chairman Prem Watsa, in committing a donation of ₹300 crore to fund the school's next 50 years' growth strategy.

Narayen, who was conferred the national award, Padma Shri, in 2019, always maintained a low-key demeanour despite holding a high-profile global CXO position.

K T Rama Rao, the former IT Minister who shared the dais with him on several occasions, congratulated him on his "incredible run as the CEO of Adobe" over 18 years.

"Humility and empathy are the hallmarks of strong leaders like Shantanu. Always admired his love for India and particularly for our city, Hyderabad," he said.

Noida airport expects to handle 4 m passengers this calendar year

Aneesh Phadnis

Mumbai

Noida International Airport (NIA) expects to handle upto 4 million passengers in CY 2026, its developer Zurich Airport said in an investor presentation this week.

The NIA received an aerodrome licence from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation on March 6.

While the date for its inauguration has not been finalised, the NIA is expected to commence operations within 30-45 days after receiving the aerodrome licence, Zurich Airport said.

In the initial period, the airport will handle domestic and cargo flights with day-time operations.

Operations are expected to ramp up in three-four months.

ROBUST NETWORK

"We are working closely with airlines to develop a robust and well-balanced international network," it said.

The NIA added that the airport's security programme is being reviewed by Bureau of Civil Aviation Security and approval expected in due course. "Subsequently, NIA will co-ordinate with all partners to plan formal inauguration and commencement of commercial operations," it added.

Meanwhile, Akasa Air and the NIA jointly announced setting up of a maintenance repair and overhaul (MRO) facility at the airport.

Under the agreement, Akasa Air will operate a state-of-the-art MRO facility within the airport premises, offering advanced MRO services at the NIA, supporting a broad spectrum of aircraft maintenance activities.

IndiGo tickets get costlier over fuel surcharge levy

Our Bureau

Mumbai

IndiGo has imposed a fuel surcharge ranging from ₹425-₹2,300 in view of sharp rise in fuel prices.

The surcharge will come into effect from Friday midnight.

While tickets on domestic and South Asia routes will get costlier by ₹425, West Asia travel will get costlier by ₹900.

Tickets to South East Asia, China, Africa and Central Asia will attract ₹1,800 surcharge and those to Europe will get pricier by ₹2,300.

HIKING FARES

IndiGo is the second Indian carrier after Air India to impose the levy and joins growing list of airlines hiking fares.

International Air Trans-



port Association's jet fuel monitor indicates 85 per cent increase in fuel price in the region.

"Aviation turbine fuel represents a significant share of airlines' operating cost. This sudden and steep increase will have a material impact on all airlines' costs and network, including IndiGo's. While offsetting the entire impact of this fuel price surge requires a very substantial adjustment to fares, IndiGo has introduced a relatively smaller amount as a fuel charge keeping in mind the consequential burden on customers," the airline said.

HC allows partial defreezing of WinZO assets to pay salaries

Vallari Sanzgiri

Mumbai

The Karnataka High Court allowed ZO Pvt Ltd, owned by parent company of WinZO, to partially defreeze contentious accounts by dismissing an appeal by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) challenging the same.

In late November, the ED had frozen around ₹505 crore worth of WinZO assets such as bank balances, bonds, FDRs and mutual funds under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002 (PMLA) for fraudulent practices leading to financial losses of users.

LIMITED ACCESS

A single judge order later granted the company limited access to the accounts to pay salaries of 220 employees.



The Karnataka High Court dismissed the ED's appeal

However, the ED challenged this order.

Now, the division bench comprising Justices Anu Sivaraman and Vijaykumar A Patil upheld the earlier order, holding that permitting salary payments was reasonable.

"Having considered the contentions advanced and the decisions of the Apex Court on the point, espe-

cially in Vijay Madanlal Choudhary's case (supra), we notice that the Apex Court has clearly held that the proceeds of crime have to be linked to a predicate offence.

CRIMINAL ACTIVITY

"It is only such property which is derived or obtained directly or indirectly as a result of criminal activity relating to a scheduled offence that can be regarded as 'proceeds of crime'. In the instant case, there is no such allegation as against the respondent... The contention of the learned ASGI that the entire amount in the possession of the respondent — Zo Private Limited as well as its parent entity — Winzo Games Private Limited represents proceeds of crime cannot be accepted," said the court.

From start-up to global giant, Bharat Bio's 30-year journey

Our Bureau

Hyderabad

What started as a small biotech start-up in Shamirpet's Genome Valley 30 years ago has now emerged as a major global vaccine company. Krishna Ella, the Co-Founder of Bharat Biotech, incidentally also helped groom the valley, which now houses some marquee biotech companies worldwide.

With over 220 patents and a workforce of over 4,000 employees, the Hyderabad-based company delivered over 9 billion vaccine doses to over 125 countries in 30 years.

The company has celebrated "30 years of scientific



SIGNIFICANT MILESTONE. Bharat Biotech Co-Founders Krishna and Suchitra Ella launch a logo to mark the 30th anniversary of the company

innovation, public health impact, and its continued commitment to protecting lives in India and around the world". Commemorating this significant milestone, the company unveiled a special anniversary logo symbol-

ising its three-decade legacy of excellence and impact.

The logo was unveiled by its founders, Krishna Ella, Executive Chairman, and Suchitra Ella, Managing Director, at its Genome Valley facility. The celebration

marked the beginning of a year-long calendar of initiatives that highlighted the company's journey and reaffirmed its focus on advancing global health.

CATALYTIC ROLE

"As one of the earliest anchor industries in the region, the company played a catalytic role in transforming the region into Genome Valley, a globally-recognised biotechnology hub, now acknowledged as Asia's largest life sciences cluster," Ella said.

"Over three decades, Bharat Biotech has helped position India as a trusted innovator and supplier of affordable, high-quality vaccines to the world," he said. "Thirty years ago we star-

ted Bharat Biotech with a simple but powerful belief that Indian science can solve global health challenges. Our strength has always been our scientists, our proprietary technologies, and our commitment to innovation with purpose," he said.

From its early breakthrough in developing one of the world's most affordable recombinant Hepatitis B vaccines, the company went on to develop vaccines that form an integral part of national and global immunisation programmes, including vaccines against Covid-19, Rotavirus, Japanese Encephalitis and Malaria, reinforcing its commitment to advancing equitable healthcare worldwide.

businessline.

SATURDAY - MARCH 14-2026

Company	Prev	Close	Open	High	Low	Qty	52WH	52WL	PE	BSECI
200 Microns [S]	163.09	157.21	161.53	163.24	156.36	107.77	284.10	160.05	10	157.20
3M India [S]	145.00	145.00	145.00	145.00	145.00	145.00	145.00	145.00	145.00	145.00
3i Infotech [S]	13.14	12.81	13.37	13.37	12.71	550.90	27.5	12.68	-	-
3M India [S]	34905	32805.040	34905.040	34905.040	32700.00	767	38300.00	26800.05	14	32871.00
SPAISA [S]	301.80	300.10	298.00	300.05	295.15	46.74	348.00	287.95	22	301.55
3i Infotech [S]	594.05	555.00	594.05	594.05	552.00	210.35	1130.00	543.50	60	555.40

A

Adhaar Hsg	475.95	499.75	470.00	475.00	453.00	42.56	547.00	399.35	-	-	
Adi [S]	164.00	164.00	164.00	164.00	164.00	164.00	164.00	164.00	164.00	164.00	
Adi Int'l [S]	46.00	420.75	449.75	449.75	445.25	1148.24	1149.00	438.20	41	420.85	
Aarti Pharm	678.65	650.80	674.00	681.55	646.00	27.32	97.10	574.45	-	-	
Adani [S]	1172.00	1172.00	1172.00	1172.00	1172.00	1172.00	1172.00	1172.00	1172.00	1172.00	
AB Capital	31.95	310.75	319.00	320.00	305.90	3871.62	369.25	158.70	27	319.45	
AB Capital	40.50	40.50	40.50	40.50	40.50	40.50	40.50	40.50	40.50	40.50	
AB Capital	17.01	16.87	16.96	17.12	16.70	31.01	61.41	22.98	16.75	-	
AB Capital	115.00	115.00	115.00	115.00	115.00	115.00	115.00	115.00	115.00	115.00	
AB Sun Life	110.05	932.90	990.10	996.00	922.50	34.67	104.56	556.45	-	-	
ABB [S]	6400.9	6352.50	6439.50	6560.00	6239.50	1070.96	6430.00	4590.05	81	6394.60	
ABB [S]	139.00	139.00	139.00	139.00	139.00	139.00	139.00	139.00	139.00	139.00	
Abbott [S]	266.05	266.00	264.00	275.00	262.00	7.31	392.15	260.00	38	269.10	
ABFL [S]	60.77	59.28	62.00	62.00	59.10	3563.96	59.71	59.26	-	-	
ABFL [S]	120.78	115.93	118.00	119.96	114.10	50.19	120.75	114.05	13	118.80	
ABFL [S]	143.00	143.00	143.00	143.00	143.00	143.00	143.00	143.00	143.00	143.00	
ACCCELTA	1200.13	1074.60	1206.00	1209.00	1170.00	12.06	1524.55	1135.05	15	116.85	
ACME Solar	248.00	256.21	243.00	262.00	239.01	1462.74	243.00	172.63	-	-	
ACME Solar	865.85	840.57	843.25	872.25	837.00	2.11	1390.00	77.25	23	840.50	
Acutea Chem	2187.70	2083.20	2150.00	2187.00	2071.00	38.98	2553.65	1040.50	-	-	
Adani Ent [S]	200.02	196.11	199.20	200.00	194.55	119.55	46.175	185.00	97	196.30	
Adani Green	866.55	861.35	865.25	878.75	848.00	675.643	1179.20	762.00	192	867.75	
Adani Ports [S]	331.50	332.00	332.00	332.00	332.00	332.00	332.00	332.00	332.00	332.00	
Adani Pwr [S]	149.11	146.57	151.00	153.90	145.30	45.947	182.75	94.41	18	146.70	
Adani T Gas	60.67	56.55	62.00	64.48	55.40	331.842	45.78	46.20	-	-	
Adani T Gas	176.00	176.00	176.00	176.00	176.00	176.00	176.00	176.00	176.00	176.00	
Adani T Gas	100.40	99.20	100.80	102.70	98.00	224.01	106.70	73.00	-	-	
ADP Foods [S]	186.05	181.31	186.05	186.05	179.55	75	181.00	168.80	21	181.60	
AdvalaBial	101.10	101.10	101.10	101.10	101.10	101.10	101.10	101.10	101.10	101.10	
AdvalaBial	161.00	161.00	161.00	161.00	161.00	161.00	161.00	161.00	161.00	161.00	
AdvalaBial	45.00	45.00	45.00	45.00	45.00	45.00	45.00	45.00	45.00	45.00	
AdvalaBial	99.50	99.50	99.50	99.50	99.50	99.50	99.50	99.50	99.50	99.50	
AdvalaBial	150.00	150.00	150.00	150.00	150.00	150.00	150.00	150.00	150.00	150.00	
AdvalaBial	10.66	98.22	102.47	104.00	95.00	133.22	124.00	96.50	-	-	
Advent Hotel	173.00	165.57	169.31	171.15	155.65	29.92	34.50	155.66	-	-	
Advent Hotel	63.25	60.19	63.99	63.99	60.05	54.92	94.50	59.00	33	27.75	
Aegis Log [S]	13.75	11.81	11.47	11.95	11.01	39.72	10.20	18.24	-	-	
Aegis Vopak [S]	119.57	116.80	115.41	119.57	113.95	109.94	114.00	113.95	-	-	
Aegion [S]	23.19	23.19	23.19	23.19	23.19	23.19	23.19	23.19	23.19	23.19	
Aeroflex [S]	71.03	68.57	71.00	71.00	68.22	22.86	11.30	68.22	-	-	
Aether Ind [S]	104.75	100.55	104.90	105.40	99.10	121.89	103.60	72.00	-	-	
Aether Ind [S]	27.85	27.85	27.85	27.85	27.85	27.85	27.85	27.85	27.85	27.85	
Affle [S]	137.73	138.10	137.73	137.73	135.05	237.25	138.60	122.105	148	133.50	
Afford Robo	16.34	15.90	16.43	16.42	15.80	43.9	53.40	15.83	-	-	
Agawal Ind [S]	440.00	440.00	440.00	440.00	440.00	440.00	440.00	440.00	440.00	440.00	
Agawal Ind [S]	31.25	30.50	31.25	31.25	30.40	104.08	104.00	22.74	-	-	
Ahluwalia [S]	762.50	765.75	768.00	775.00	740.00	113.61	1129.20	704.05	19	767.75	
Ahluwalia [S]	159.45	158.87	172.00	173.00	156.00	159.32	229.45	59.84	-	-	
Ajanta Pha [S]	21.59	30.90	30.63	32.80	32.00	30.06	15.46	31.64	202.05	40	30.28
Ajan Ag	47.05	46.05	46.80	47.20	45.90	156.26	75.20	45.90	-	-	
Almera [S]	12.16	11.79	12.22	12.22	11.65	33.17	22.23	11.50	21	11.75	
Alk Ind [S]	90.05	90.05	90.05	90.05	90.05	90.05	90.05	90.05	90.05	90.05	
Alkums Drugs	49.80	49.80	49.70	49.90	49.80	49.80	49.80	49.80	49.80	49.80	
Alko Ind [S]	291.90	286.60	290.10	292.40	284.00	20.21	309.25	264.05	35	287.55	
Alkem Pharm [S]	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	12.00	
Alkem Pharm [S]	82.97	80.75	82.50	83.00	80.00	37.76	125.70	82.69	15	81.05	
Allogiant Fin [S]	54.57	54.99	55.00	55.65	54.00	98.77	61.70	49.54	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	339.40	349.90	344.00	347.00	347.00	347.00	347.00	347.00	347.00	347.00	
Allogiant Fin [S]	10.00	10.00	10.00	10.00	10.00	10.00	10.00	10.00	10.00	10.00	
Allogiant Fin [S]	130.10	127.80	125.00	129.70	125.00	10.54	144.80	129.70	36	126.50	
Allogiant Fin [S]	7.90	7.72	8.00	8.00	7.70	57.99	38.18	7.39	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	10.35	9.96	10.30	10.35	9.86	97.34	26.50	10.120	41	9.95	
Allogiant Fin [S]	66.30	64.51	64.60	64.85	63.98	43.81	62.22	63.98	27.00	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	19.24	19.24	19.24	19.24	19.24	19.24	19.24	19.24	19.24	19.24	
Allogiant Fin [S]	13.30	13.03	13.18	13.18	12.95	341.705	23.25	12.88	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	38.08	36.65	37.70	38.25	36.15	123.24	43.80	37.80	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	78.90	78.70	78.95	79.40	77.00	44.23	109.00	77.00	156	64.15	
Allogiant Fin [S]	15.00	15.00	15.00	15.00	15.00	15.00	15.00	15.00	15.00	15.00	
Allogiant Fin [S]	46.45	42.55	44.55	44.60	42.40	485.66	34.20	44.65	29	42.60	
Allogiant Fin [S]	54.80	54.50	54.65	55.00	54.25	140.7	78.95	54.05	27	54.50	
Allogiant Fin [S]	49.20	47.55	48.80	49.15	47.50	19.47	79.45	48.31	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	46.90	45.00	46.90	47.00	45.80	48.00	158.74	36.15	56	44.90	
Allogiant Fin [S]	131.36	128.77	132.90	132.93	123.92	52.29	206.10	103.22	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	41.61	41.61	41.61	41.61	41.61	41.61	41.61	41.61	41.61	41.61	
Allogiant Fin [S]	72.28	70.98	72.52	73.71	69.25	25.55	87.99	63.27	9	70.65	
Allogiant Fin [S]	20.17	21.58	21.22	21.68	20.83	68.03	104.02	53.285	208.63	-	-
Allogiant Fin [S]	121.15	121.15	121.15	121.15	121.15	121.15	121.15	121.15	121.15	121.15	
Allogiant Fin [S]	57.85	54.20	56.22	56.86	53.10	20.83	76.97	35.70	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	64.90	64.05	64.40	64.60	63.05	170.39	87.30	57.915	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	48.55	46.15	48.44	48.44	45.85	136.13	69.30	40.85	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	29.80	29.80	29.80	29.80	29.80	29.80	29.80	29.80	29.80	29.80	
Allogiant Fin [S]	126.10	123.50	126.00	126.80	123.20	15.13	140.00	68.10	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	94.50	89.80	93.05	93.00	88.80	105.00	114.71	42.700	37	89.72	
Allogiant Fin [S]	23.00	23.00	23.00	23.00	23.00	23.00	23.00	23.00	23.00	23.00	
Allogiant Fin [S]	34.60	32.40	34.05	34.50	32.00	29.13	46.00	33.50	32	32.45	
Allogiant Fin [S]	20.90	19.32	20.08	20.13	19.08	56.04	330.00	196.50	109	19.34	
Allogiant Fin [S]	210.84	206.87	208.00	209.55	199.57	440.03	354.65	101.05	74	208.80	
Allogiant Fin [S]	21.00	21.00	21.00	21.00	21.00	21.00	21.00	21.00	21.00	21.00	
Allogiant Fin [S]	41.05	40.70	41.50	42.60	40.96	36.00	332.34	49.45	252.10	-	-
Allogiant Fin [S]	40.00	39.75	40.00	40.00	39.75	40.00	40.00	39.75	40.00	40.00	
Allogiant Fin [S]	22.74	22.01	22.25	22.78	21.23	150.53	36.40	21.827	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	56.85	59.20	56.45	59.80	55.20	31.02	72.60	48.00	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	15.04	15.04	15.04	15.04	15.04	15.04	15.04	15.04	15.04	15.04	
Allogiant Fin [S]	33.95	32.30	33.40	34.00	32.45	40.02	49.59	23.10	11	32.15	
Allogiant Fin [S]	71.10	69.14	71.49	71.49	68.23	19.48	120.00	61.00	-	-	
Allogiant Fin [S]	107.10	107.10	107.10	107.10	107.10	107.10	107.10	107.10	107.10	107.10	
Allogiant Fin [S]	10.95	10.48	10.95	10.95	10.48	10.95	10.95	10.48	10.95	10.95	
Allogiant Fin [S]	137.90	136.80	136.80	137.90	133.00	37.62	184.95	111.10	33	136.35	
Allogiant Fin [S]	36.85	35.04	36.85	37.00	35.25	24.39	81.15	36.53	10	35.85	
Allogiant Fin [S]	24.25	22.25	24.25	24.25	22.25	24.25	24.25	22.25	24.25		

